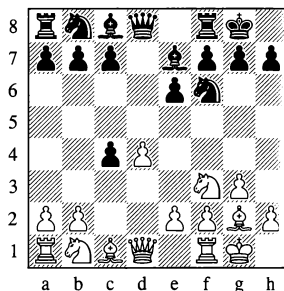


Chapter 16

Catalan 4...♘e7



6...dxc4

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1.d4 ♘f6 2.c4 e6 3.g3 d5 4.♘f3 ♘e7 5.♘g2 0-0 6.0-0 dxc4

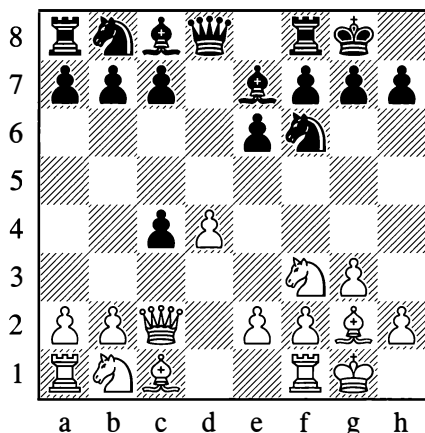
7.♞c2

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1.d4 ♘f6 2.c4 e6 3.g3 d5 4.♘f3 ♚e7 5.♙g2 0-0 6.0-0 dxc4

This is Black's most popular reaction to the Catalan. He can also shuffle the move order, for instance by starting with 4...dxc4, without it making much of a difference.

7.♖c2



This is by far White's most popular continuation. Needless to say, it is a permanent battleground for the world's elite players. We will start by analysing **A) 7...c5** and **B) 7...♙d7**, neither of which have the best reputation, but which demand a degree of accuracy all the same. Next we will consider **C) 7...b5!?**, which, amazingly, only came to be regarded as a serious option in the years after *GM 1* was published. Finally, the main line is of course **D) 7...a6**.

A) 7...c5

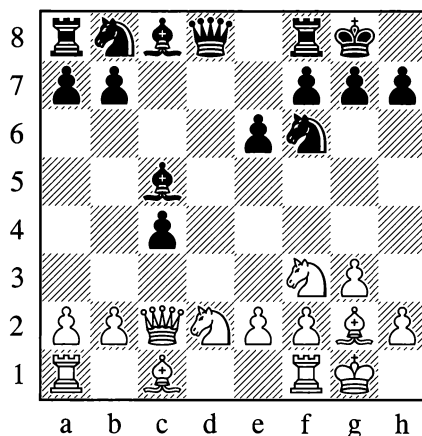
Obviously this is not the way to solve Black's problems, as White keeps unpleasant pressure along the h1-a8 diagonal.

8.dxc5 ♙xc5

8...♘c6 9.♘bd2 gives Black nothing better than transposing to the main line with 9...♙xc5.

9.♘bd2!

I believe this to be more precise than 9.♖xc4 ♖e7 10.♘c3, though not for the exact reasons given in *GM 1*. 10...♘bd7! (Previously I suggested that 10...a6 should be okay for Black, but this does not look at all convincing after 11.♘g5!?, for instance 11...b5? 12.♖h4 ♙b7, Straub – Bader, Germany 2003, and now the elegant 13.♘xh7!N would have won a pawn.) 11.♘a4 b6 Black was more or less okay in Vesely – Janosi, Internet 2012.



9...♘c6

9...♘bd7 10.♘xc4 obviously favours White. 10...h6 has been played by Smyslov and has brought Black two draws, but the simple 11.♙d1N ♖e7 12.a3 a5 13.♙e3 gives White a clear advantage.

10.♘xc4 ♖e7

Definitely the most natural move, although a couple of alternatives are worth mentioning.

10...♙d7 11.♘ce5

White exploits the hanging bishop on c5 to obtain the two-bishop advantage.

11...♖b6

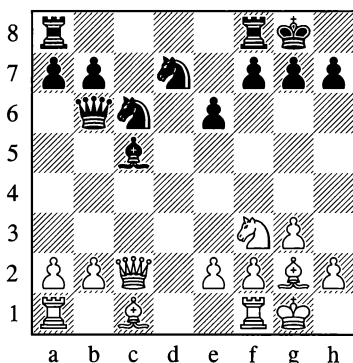
This has been used recently, and seems like the best option available.

11...♖e7 12.♘xd7 ♘xd7 13.♙g5 ♖e8?! (Black should probably have tried 13...f6N,

but after 14.♙d2 ♖ac8 15.♖ac1± the weakening of the e6-pawn and the h3-c8 diagonal gives White additional targets.) 14.♖ad1 ♙e7 15.♙f4± Wojtkiewicz – Voelker, Philadelphia 1999.

12.♘xd7 ♘xd7

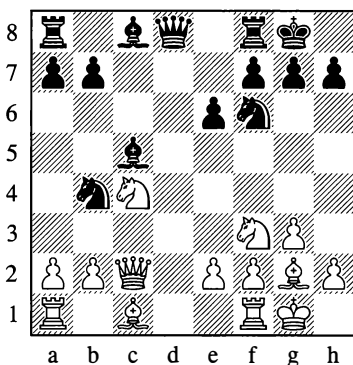
This was Boos – Dunlop, email 2012, and now I recommend the accurate:



13.♙d2N ♖ac8 14.♖ac1 ♖fd8 15.a3±

White would retain a pleasant edge, thanks to his bishop pair.

10...♘b4!?



This is perhaps the most interesting try for Black, and it was not mentioned in *GM 1*.

11.♞b1 b5

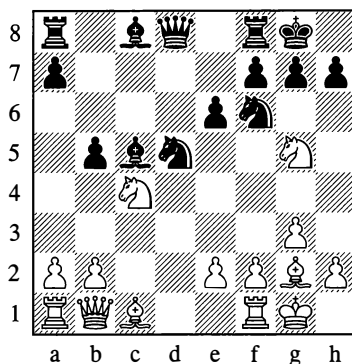
I also considered 11...♙d7N 12.♘fe5 ♘bd5, but found that 13.a4! ♞e7 14.b3 ♖fd8 15.♙b2 retains a pleasant edge for White.

12.♘g5!?

Otherwise Black would solve his problems by neutralizing the Catalan bishop with ...♙b7.

12...♘bd5

Now in Azarov – Berndt, Panormo 2001, White could have maintained some initiative with:



13.♙e3!N ♘xe3

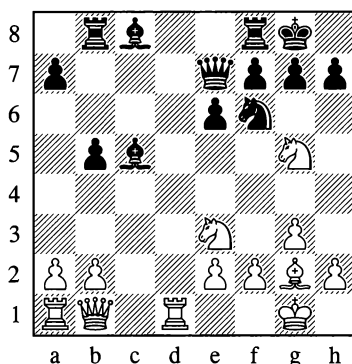
13...♙xe3 14.♘xe3 h6 15.♘xd5 exd5 16.♘f3± gives White a pleasant position playing against the isolated pawn.

13...♞c7 14.♙xc5 ♞xc5 15.♘e5 h6 16.♘e4 ♘xe4 17.♞xe4 ♞d6 18.♞d4± also favours White.

14.♘e3 ♖b8

Black has no time for 14...♙xe3?!, as after 15.fxe3 White threatens ♖xf6 in addition to the rook on a8.

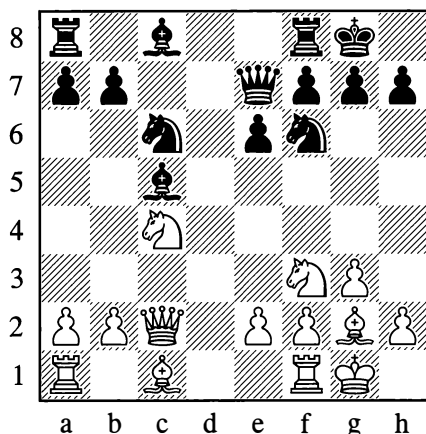
15.♙d1 ♞e7



16.♘g4! g6 17.♘xf6+ ♞xf6 18.♘e4 ♞e5

19. ♖xc5 ♜xc5 20. b4

20. ♜d3 is also possible. In both cases the position is rather simplified, but White's pieces are more active and he can keep playing without any risk.



11. ♖fe5

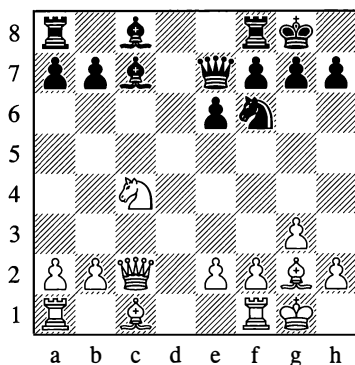
Increasing the pressure along the h1-a8 diagonal.

11... ♖xc5

White should not be afraid of 11... ♖d4, when 12. ♜d1 ♜d8 13. e3 ♖c6 14. ♖xc6 bxc6 15. ♜a4 gave him an obvious advantage in Kern – Siepmann, Recklinghausen 2001.

12. ♖xc5 ♜c7

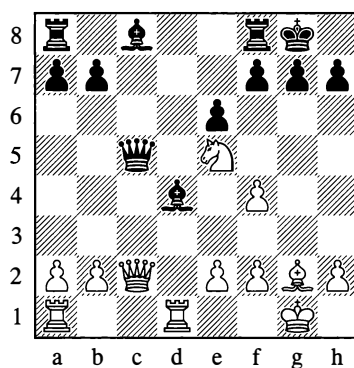
12... ♗d6 13. ♖c4 ♗c7



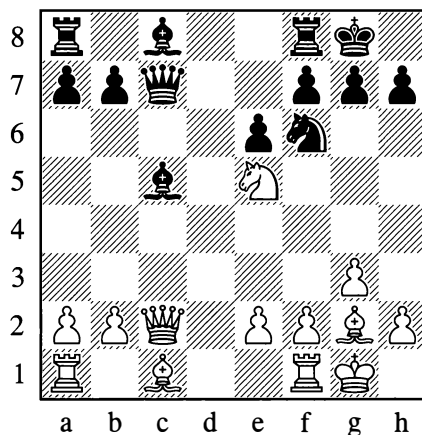
14. b3! ♜d8 15. ♗a3 ♜e8 16. ♜fd1± is obviously

not an improvement for Black, Tukmakov – Ekstroem, Zürich 1999.

12... ♗d4 13. ♗f4 ♖d5 14. ♜fd1 ♖xf4 15. gxf4 ♜c5 is a recent try, but hardly an improvement. (15... ♗b6 16. e3 f6 17. ♖c4 ♗c7 18. ♜d2 ♜b8 19. ♜ad1 gave White a serious advantage in Yusupov – Gerusel, Moscow 1981)



16. ♜xc5 ♗xc5 17. ♜ac1 ♗b6 18. ♖c4! The endgame was extremely unpleasant for Black in Zhao Xue – Ding Yixin, Xinghua 2010.



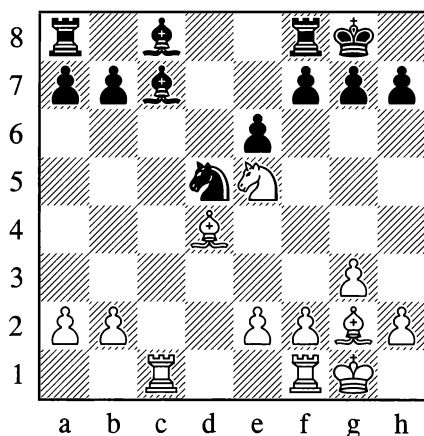
13. ♗c3 ♗d6

13... ♜xc5 occurred in V. Mikhalevski – Goletiani, Kapuskasing 2004, and now 14. ♗xc5N ♜e8 15. ♜fd1 would have given White a large advantage.

14. ♜xc7 ♗xc7 15. ♗d4

I recommended this as an improvement in *GM 1*, and it has since been played in one game.

15...♘d5 16.♞ac1



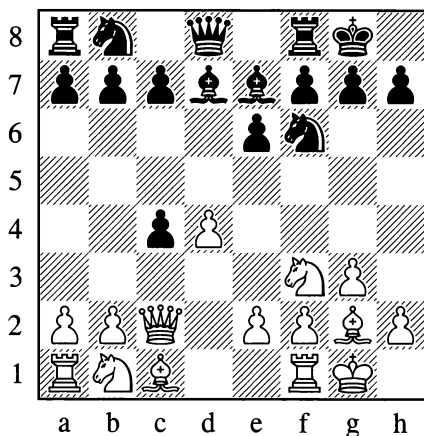
16...♗xe5

16...f6 17.♘d3±

17.♗xe5 ♗d7 18.e4 ♘b6 19.♞fd1 ♗c6
20.f3±

With the bishop pair and more active pieces, White had achieved a Catalan player's dream position in Saric – Zorko, Nova Gorica 2009.

B) 7...♗d7



Black intends to post the bishop on c6. There is an obvious parallel with the later variation D4, coverage of which begins on page 268. You can think of this as a 'lazy version' for Black: he has avoided the major theoretical paths of 7...a6 8.♞xc4, but the absence of the moves ...a6 and a2-a4 helps White, as Black will not have the b4-outpost for his pieces.

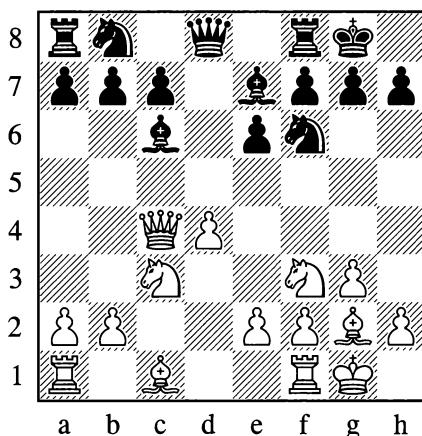
8.♞xc4

8.♘e5 may look promising at first sight, but after 8...♘c6! (but not 8...♗c6 9.♘xc6 ♘xc6 10.e3±) I found no advantage for White: 9.♘xc6 (9.♞xc4 ♘xe5 10.dxe5 ♘d5∞) 9...♗xc6 10.♗xc6 bxc6 11.♞xc4 ♞d5! Black was fine in Kiss – Bakos, Fuzesabony 2004.

8...♗c6 9.♘c3

This is the first concrete difference from the parallel variation D4, where ...a6 and a2-a4 have been played. In the latter position, the knight development runs into the annoying ...b5!, when Black equalizes comfortably.

9.♗f4 is less convincing after 9...♘bd7 10.♘c3 ♗d6!. Sure, White can play 11.♗d2N and get a modest edge, just as in the later variation D431, but the text move is stronger and more ambitious. Our aim should be to make Black suffer for avoiding the 7...a6 variation.



Black has two main options: **B1) 9...a6** and **B2) 9...♖bd7**.

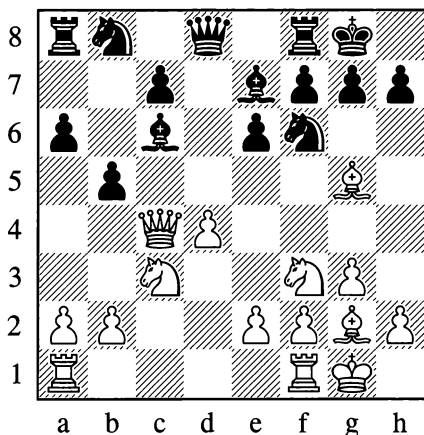
9...♗e4 has also been played, but 10.♙d3 ♗xc3 11.bxc3 ♗d7 12.♙e1 leads straight to variation B2.

B1) 9...a6 10.♗g5 b5

Another direction is 10...♗bd7 11.♙fe1, when Black has tried two ideas:

a) 11...♙b8 prepares ...b5, as after ♙xc6 ♙b6 the queen will be trapped. However, the simple 12.a4 is a good answer, and after 12...♗d5 13.♗xe7 ♗xe7 14.e4 a5 15.b3 White was clearly better in Vaganian – Smagin, Germany 1993.

b) 11...♗b6 12.♙d3 h6 occurred in the recent game Sethuraman – Surendran, Calcutta 2014, when White exchanged on f6. I would prefer to keep the dark-squared bishop with 13.♗d2N (or even 13.♗c1!?N); there is no need to eliminate the knight, as White has already established control over the e4-square. Play may continue 13...♗fd5 14.e4 ♗xc3 15.♙xc3 with a pleasant edge to White.



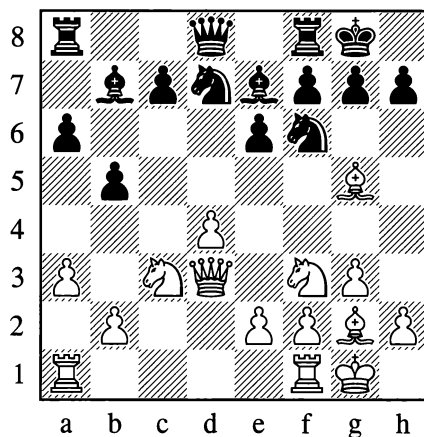
11.♙d3 ♗bd7 12.a3!

This move is a further reminder as to why

the version with the pawn on a2 instead of a4 is favourable for White. Now ...b4 has been prevented, and White's control over the e4-square has been strengthened. The last move also prepares b2-b4, which will prevent the ...c5 advance.

12...♗b7

Practice has also seen: 12...h6 13.♗xf6 (This has always been played, but 13.♗f4!?N certainly deserves consideration.) 13...♗xf6 14.♙ac1 ♗xf3? This is an obvious concession which gives White a big positional advantage. (14...♙b8N is better, although 15.♙fd1 ♙b6 16.♙c2 ♗b7 17.e4 maintains a pleasant edge for White) 15.♗xf3± Stefansson – Delgado Ramirez, Havana 2001.



13.b4

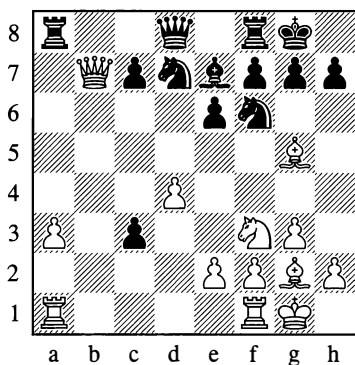
Needless to say, White does not intend to grant Black permission to play ...c5.

13...♗d5

This is a recent innovation, but it does not really change anything.

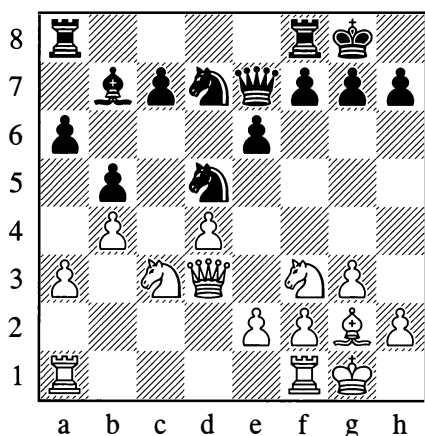
13...h6 14.♗xf6 ♗xf6 15.♗e5 ♗xg2 16.♗xg2 ♗d6 17.♗c6! ♙e8 18.♙f3 gave White a big positional advantage in Gleizerov – Akhmadeev, Kstovo 1997.

13...a5 14.♖xb5 axb4 15.♖xb7 bxc3 occurred in Wojtkiewicz – Berset, Geneva 1995, and now I would like to point out an improvement that I overlooked in *GM 1*:



16.♙e5! N ♖b8 (16...♙xe5 17.♖xa8! wins the exchange) 17.♖c6 ♙xe5 18.dxe5 ♙d5 19.♙xe7 ♖xe7 20.e4 ♙b6 21.♖fc1± White will soon be a pawn up with a clear advantage.

14.♙xe7 ♖xe7



15.♙d2! N

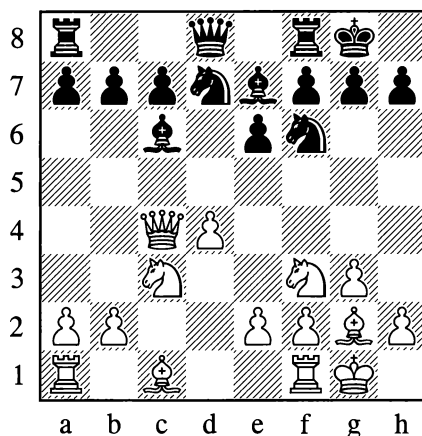
A significant improvement over 15.♙e4 f5! 16.♙c5 ♙xc5 17.bxc5 ♙f6! when White had only slightly better chances in a double-edged position in Laxman – Liew Chee Meng, Kuala Lumpur 2014.

15...f5 16.♖ac1 ♖ac8 17.♖fe1 ♙a8 18.e4

♙xc3 19.♖xc3±

White is in full control, and Black will suffer for his pawn weaknesses.

B2) 9...♙bd7



This natural developing move has been the most popular choice.

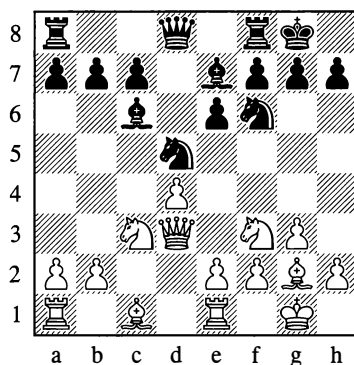
10.♖e1

I prefer this calm move over the more popular 10.♖d3.

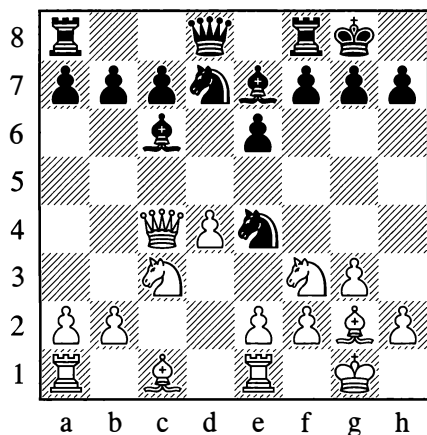
10...♙e4

White was threatening e2-e4, establishing full control over the centre.

10...♙b6 11.♖d3 leaves Black unable to prevent White's plan. A good illustrative example continued: 11...♙bd5



12.e4 ♖xc3 13.bxc3 b5 14.♗e5 ♕e8 15.c4 c5 16.d5 White was clearly better in Pogonina – Sukhareva, Moscow 2009.



11.♞d3!

Previously I recommended 11.d5 exd5 12.♗xd5 ♗b6 13.♗xe7† ♞xe7 14.♞c2 as played in Jovanic – Lazovic, Pula 1999, but White's advantage is not that great, especially after the accurate 14...♗f6!N.

11...♗xc3 12.bxc3 f5

A natural attempt to prevent e2-e4.

12...b6? is just a blunder, and after 13.♗g5! ♕xg5 14.♕xc6 Black had to part with the exchange in Ki. Georgiev – Can, Sarajevo 2011.

13.♗d2

The fight for the e4-square continues!

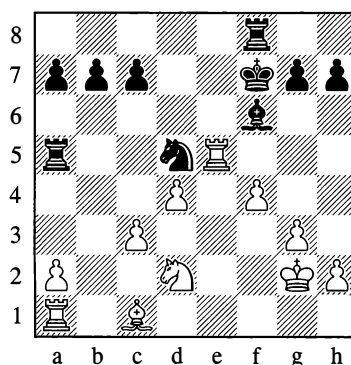
13...♕xg2 14.♗xg2 ♗b6

Another game continued 14...c5 15.♞b1 ♗b6 16.e4 cxd4 17.cxd4 ♞d7 18.♗f3 ♞ac8 19.♕f4 and White retained a solid advantage in Grochowski – Krygier, email 2008.

15.e4 ♞d7 16.♞b1 ♞c6

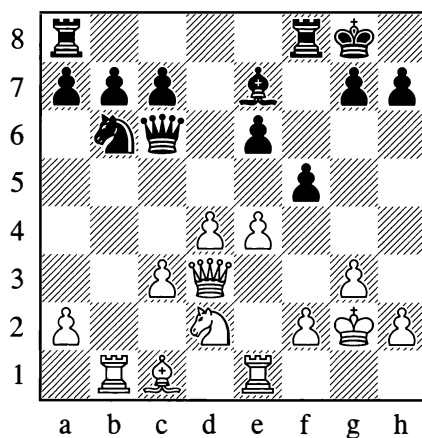
16...♞ac8 makes White's task was easier after: 17.exf5! ♞xf5 18.♞e4 ♞cf8 19.f4 ♞a5

20.♞a1 ♗d5 21.♞xe6† ♞xe6 22.♞xe6 ♗f7 23.♞e5 ♕f6



24.♗b3! ♕xe5 25.♗xa5 ♕f6 26.♕d2± White emerged with an extra pawn in Ahleao – Andriytx, email 2012.

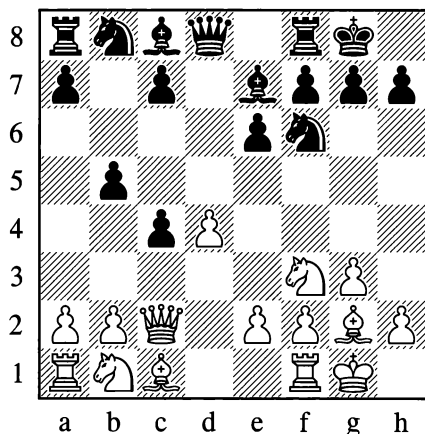
We have been following Szczepanski – Ottesen, email 2009. Here I like:



17.♞b3!N ♞ab8 18.♞b5 ♞xb5 19.♞xb5

White has a pleasant endgame with continuing pressure.

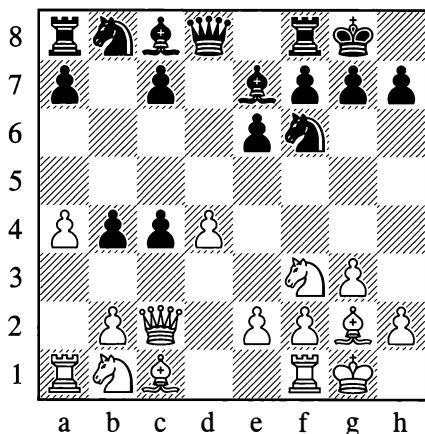
C) 7...b5!?



This move was practically unknown when *GM 1* was published, but it has since come to be recognized as a serious alternative to the main line.

8.a4 b4

It is well known that 8...c6? is a serious mistake due to 9.axb5 cxb5 10.♘g5! when White is almost winning: 10...h6 (Obviously 10...♘d5 is not possible due to mate on h7.) 11.♘xf7! (even stronger than 11.♙xa8) 11...♞xf7 12.♙xa8 ♜xd4 13.♙e3 ♜g4 14.♙f3 ♜h3 This occurred in Plassmann – Blanke, Germany 2007, and now the simple 15.♞xa7N would have given White an easily winning position.



9.♘fd2!

Several games have shown that 9.♘e5 ♜xd4 10.♙xa8 ♜xe5∞ is extremely double-edged, and most strong players have switched to the text move.

9...c6

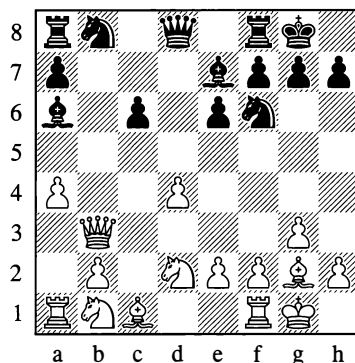
Other options are rarely played, and not without reason.

9...b3

This forcing approach is too risky.

10.♜xc4 ♙a6 11.♜xb3 c6

This position first occurred in Ashwin – Rusev, Golden Sands 2013. Instead of the natural 12.♘c3, which somehow failed to impress in the game, I propose:



12.♘e4!N ♙xe2

Capturing the central pawn with 12...♜xd4 enables White to generate serious pressure after: 13.♙e3 ♜c4 14.♘xf6† ♙xf6 15.♜a3! ♘d7 16.♘c3±

13.♘xf6† ♙xf6 14.♞e1 ♙a6

14...♙g4 15.♜c4 ♘d7 16.a5 ♞b8 17.♘c3± also favours White.

15.♘c3 ♙xd4

15...♜xd4? is much worse due to 16.♙e3 ♜c4 17.♜a3! when the threat of ♘e4 is close to decisive.

16.♘b5 ♙b6 17.♙e3∞

White has powerful compensation.

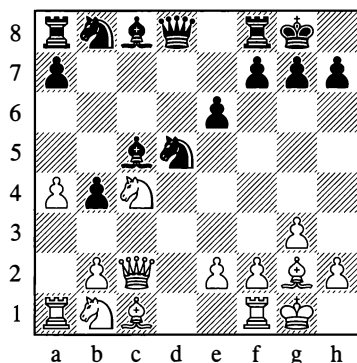
9...d5

This has occurred in several games, but without much success for Black.

10.dxc4 c5

In the event of 10...dxc6 11.e3 a6, White should be careful and anticipate Black's possible ideas. A strong stabilizing move is 12.b3!N± which leaves White with a clear positional superiority. Instead the seemingly natural 12.dbd2 was played in Yevseev – Serrano Salvador, St Petersburg 2012, when Black could have obtained counterplay with 12...b3!N 13.♖xb3 ♖b8 14.♗d1 dcb4♞, followed by ...c5, with a lot of compensation.

11.dxc5 ♗xc5



12.e4!?N

I consider this a natural improvement over 12.dbd2 d7 13.e4 d5b6 14.e5?! Melkumyan – Can, Sarajevo 2011, when 14...a6!N would have given Black a comfortable game.

12...db6

In the event of 12...df6 13.g5 b7 14.dbd2 White has a stable advantage.

13.dcd2!

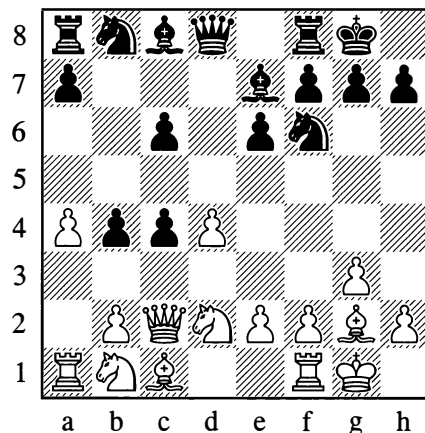
I prefer this calm regrouping over 13.de5, which seems less clear after 13...d8d7 14.a5 b3!.

13...♗c7

Black cannot play 13...e7? in view of 14.a5 d6d7 15.e5 and White wins.

14.d6b3 d6a6 15.♗d1 b7 16.a5 d7 17.f4 e5 18.e3

White has a clear positional edge.



10.dxc4 ♗xd4

Grabbing the pawn is the only challenging idea. Instead after 10...a6 11.♗d1 dbd7 12.dbd2 ♖c8 13.e4 db6 14.a5 dxc4 15.dxc4 White had a stable positional advantage in A. Mikhalevski – Hess, Wheeling 2012.

11.♗d1 ♗c5 12.e3

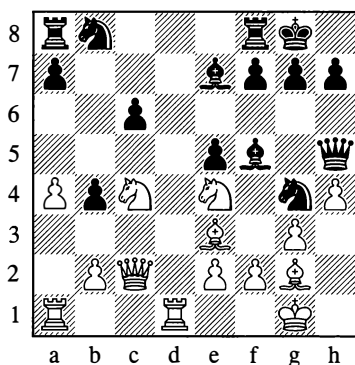
White has a lead in development and a brilliant outpost on c4. This, along with Black's undeveloped queenside, gives him a lot of play for the sacrificed pawn.

12...♗h5

So far nobody has tried 12...♗f5N, and indeed after 13.♗xf5 exf5 14.dbd2 e6 15.d6a5 followed by ♖ac1, Black is doomed to passive defence.

13.dbd2 dg4

13...e5 14.d6e4 dg4 15.h4 f5 occurred in Bu – Yang, China 2014. Black has some activity on the kingside, but it is hard to believe he can succeed this way when three of his pieces have yet to come into play. White could have obtained a clear advantage as follows:



16.♙c1!N With ideas of ♙c5 or ♗cd6.
 16...♙xe4 (16...♗e3 17.♙xe3±) 17.♙xe4
 f5 18.♙f3 e4 19.♙xg4 ♙xg4 20.♗e5 ♙xe2
 21.♙d2 ♙h5 (21...♙a6 22.♙c5 also puts Black
 under serious pressure) 22.♙c4† ♗h8 23.♙ad1
 White has a huge initiative.

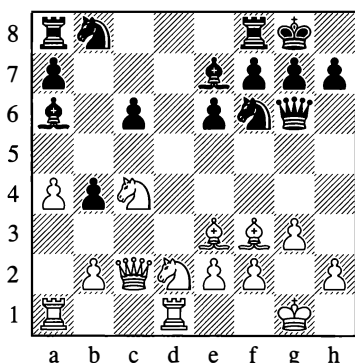
I also considered:

13...♙a6 14.♙f3!N

This is stronger than 14.♗f3 when, in Gupta
 – Munkhgal, Sharjah 2014, Black should
 have continued 14...♗d5N with unclear play.

14...♙g6

14...♗g4 15.♙xg4 ♙xg4 16.♙f3 ♙g6 17.♗e4±
 also gives White a lot of compensation.



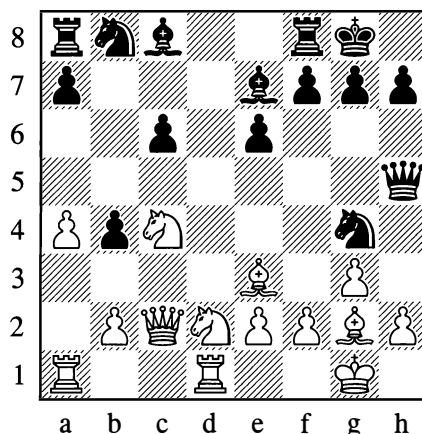
15.♗e4! ♗bd7

After 15...♗d5 16.♗e5 ♙f5 17.♙d4± the
 black queen is in danger.

16.♗a5

White easily develops his initiative, for
 instance:

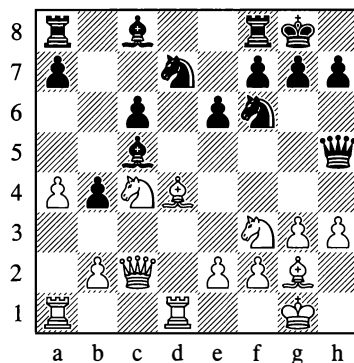
16...♗e5 17.♗xc6 ♗xf3† 18.exf3 ♙fe8
 19.♗xe7† ♙xe7 20.♙c5 ♙ee8 21.♗d6±



14.♗f3 ♗xe3

Eliminating the bishop is natural. I found
 two examples where other moves were tried:

14...♗d7?! 15.♙d4 ♙c5 (15...c5N 16.h3!
 ♗gf6 17.♙xf6 ♙xf6 18.g4 ♙g6 19.♙c1! also
 gives White a clear advantage.) 16.h3 ♗gf6
 This occurred in Sieglén – Kutzner, Berlin
 2012.



And now the simple 17.g4!N ♙g6 18.♙c1+–
 would have decided the game on the spot,
 thanks to Black's vulnerable queen.

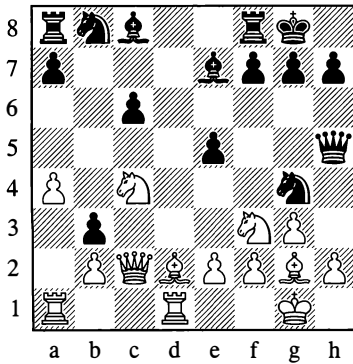
14...e5 15.♙d2!

The threat of h2-h3 is a pain for Black here
 too.

15...b3

15...♙e1N 16.♙e1± does not help Black.

The text move was played in Edvardsson – Zumsande, Reykjavik 2012. Instead of capturing on b3, which might have allowed Black some counterplay, I would prefer:



16.♞d3!N

Luring the enemy rook to d8.

16...♞d8

16...♙c5 17.♙e1 ♙e6 18.♞ac1 is clearly better for White, as Black cannot do much against the plan of h2-h3 and g3-g4.

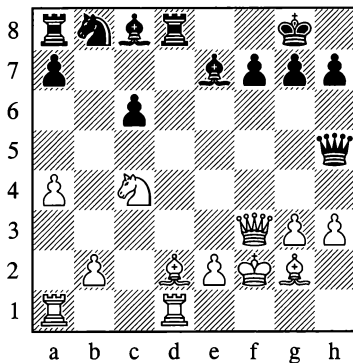
17.♞xb3 e4

The main point of White's play is that 17...♙c5? loses to 18.♙e1!, when the position of the rook on d8 starts to tell.

18.h3 ♖xf2

18...exf3? 19.hxg4 ♙xg4 20.exf3 ♙e6 21.♙b4! is winning for White.

19.♖xf2 exf3 20.♞xf3



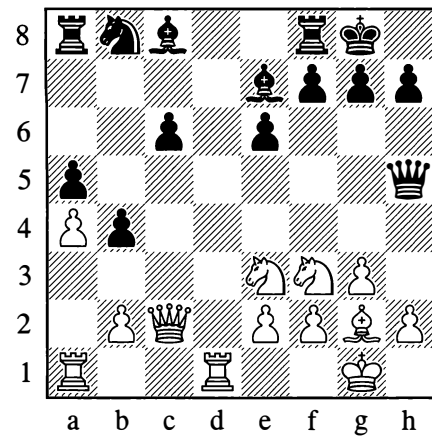
20...♞c5†

20...♞xf3† leaves White with an endgame advantage after any of the three possible recaptures; the computer's top choice is 21.♖xf3!? ♙e6 22.♖a5.

21.♖e3

White has an obvious initiative thanks to his lead in development.

15.♖xe3 a5



16.♖d4!

16.♖c4 was played in the stem game, but after 16...♙a6 White failed to prove any advantage in Gelfand – Ponomarev, Olginka 2011. The text move has since emerged as an improvement.

16...♙a6

16...♞a7 17.♞ac1 ♙a6 transposes to 17...♞a7 below.

17.♞ac1

White continues to improve his position with every move. His compensation is beyond any doubt, but it is important to understand that he can fight for an advantage.

17...♞c8

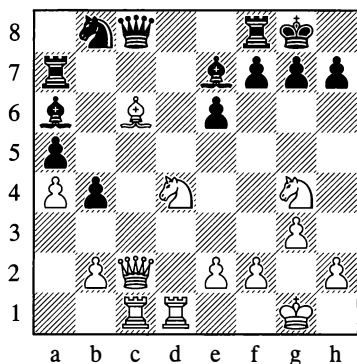
Black can also try:

17...♞a7 18.♙f3! ♞e5 19.♖g4!N

A clear improvement over 19.♘xc6?! ♘xc6 20.♙xc6 ♗b8!, when Black had absolutely no problems in Ju Wenjun – Wei Yi, Ho Chi Minh City 2012.

19...♙c7 20.♙xc6 ♙c8

20...♙c8 runs into 21.♙e4! ♙b6 22.♙b5 and White retains serious pressure.



21.♙b5!

Exchanging the light-squared bishops will enable White to attack the enemy pawns on the queenside. The following line looks pretty logical.

21...♙xc2 22.♙xc2 ♙d8 23.♙xa6 ♙xa6

23...♘xa6?! 24.♘e5±

24.♙d3 ♙ad6 25.♘b3±

With ongoing pressure.

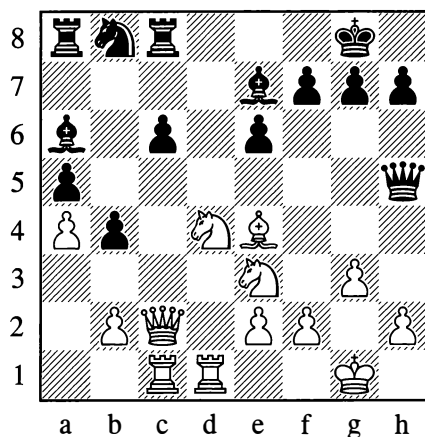
18.♙f3 ♙g6

18...♙e5N is a logical alternative, when 19.♘g4 ♙c7 20.♙e4! ♙a7 21.♘e5± seems like the right way to develop White's initiative.

19.♙e4

It is too early for a queen swap: 19.♙xg6 hxg6 20.♘b3 ♙f8 and Black should hold easily.

19...♙h5



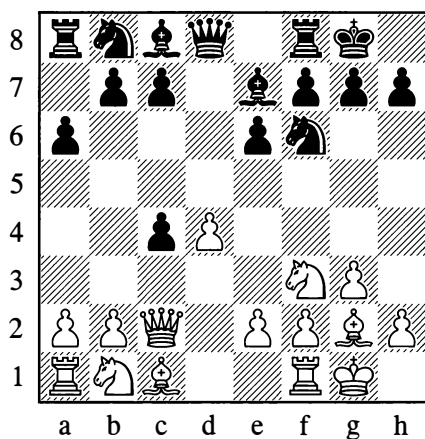
20.♙d2!?N

This is more flexible than 20.♘c4 ♙xc4 21.♙xc4 ♙a7 as occurred in Helbich – Kupsys, email 2011.

20...♙a7 21.♙cd1±

It goes without saying that White has great compensation for the pawn. Black's position remains solid, but I would definitely prefer to be playing White's side.

D) 7...a6

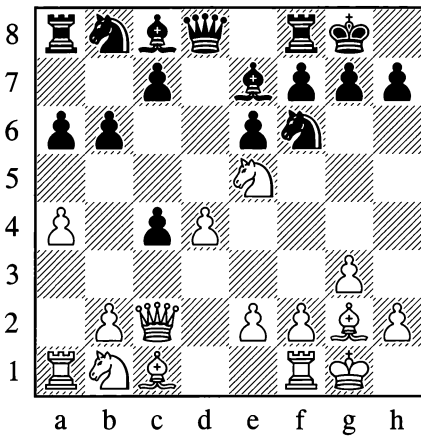


This is the classical main line, which remains popular at all levels. Here we have perhaps the most significant change of direction from *GM 1* in the entire Catalan.

8.a4

Previously I recommended 8.♖xc4 b5 9.♞c2 ♟b7 10.♙d2, but my impression at the moment is that Black has found more than one route to equality. 10...♙e4 11.♞c1 ♟b7 is one main line, while 10...♙d6 has become Black's most popular move at high levels in recent years.

The text move leads to a radically different type of game, where White prevents his opponent's queenside expansion at the cost of a slight weakening of his own queenside, especially the b4-square. At this point **D1) 8...b6**, **D2) 8...c5** and **D3) 8...♘c6** are all playable, but **D4) 8...♙d7** is the main line by far.

D1) 8...b6 9.♘e5**9...♞a7**

Black intends ...♟b7 to exchange the light-squared bishops. I was surprised to see that this has been played by such strong players as Spassky and Short.

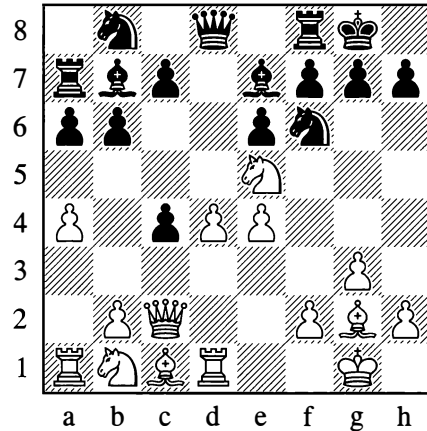
9...♘d5 does not make much sense, and after 10.♖xc4 ♟b7 11.♘c3 c6 12.♞d1 White had a dream Catalan position in Morovic Fernandez – Rodriguez Vargas, Copenhagen 1990.

10.♞d1

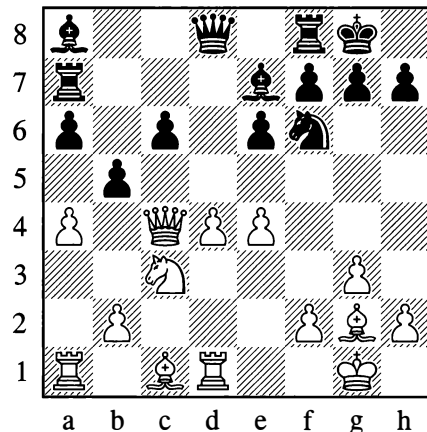
I consider this more accurate than 10.♖xc4, which allows 10...c5.

10...♟b7 11.e4!

An important move, as after 11.♟xb7 ♞xb7 12.♖xc4 c5 13.♘c3 cxd4 Black is close to equality.

**11...♘c6 12.♘xc6 ♙xc6 13.♘c3 ♙a8**

13...♟b7 was played in Adamski – Luczak, Piotrkow Trybunalski 1977, and a couple of other games, but for some reason White never chose the obvious plan of regaining the pawn with 14.♞e2N. A logical continuation is 14...♟b4 15.♙g5 ♙xc3 16.bxc3 h6 17.♙xf6 ♖xf6 18.♖xc4± and White maintains a pleasant edge.

14.♞e2 c6 15.♖xc4 b5

16.♚f1!N

An important nuance. Instead after 16.♚e2 b4 17.e5 bxc3 18.exf6 c2! 19.♚xc2 ♙xf6 Black had a decent position in Hübner – Spassky, Bad Kissingen 1980.

16...b4 17.e5 bxc3

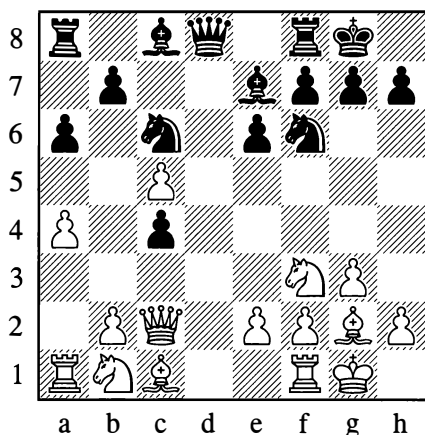
17...♙d5 18.♜e4 is clearly better for White.

18.exf6 ♙xf6 19.bxc3±

Having prevented the ...c2 idea, White changes the pawn structure and maintains an edge.

D2) 8...c5 9.dxc5 ♜c6

9...♙xc5 is likely to lead to the same thing after 10.♜bd2 ♜c6 11.♜xc4.

**10.♜a3 ♙xc5 11.♜xc4 ♚e7**

This has been by far the most popular choice in the position. Other moves also fail to bring Black an easy life, as the following brief lines illustrate:

11...♜b4 12.♚b3 ♚e7 13.♙d2 ♜bd5 14.♜fe5± was clearly better for White in Koshy – Parameswaran, New Delhi 1982.

11...♙d7 12.♜ce5 ♚e7 13.♜xd7 ♜xd7 occurred in Menezes – Kleiser, Vienna 2014.

White has more than one way to maintain an edge, but I especially like 14.♙g5!N f6 15.♙d2, when the slight weakening of Black's light squares increases the value of the Catalan bishop.

12.♜fe5 ♜xe5

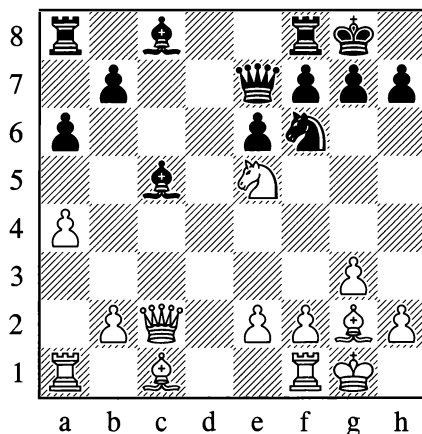
Other options hardly improve Black's chances:

12...♜d4?! 13.♚d1 ♚d8 14.♙d2 ♜e8 occurred in D. Gurevich – Schwarz, Biel 1991, and now the simple 15.e3 ♜f5 16.♚b3± would have given White a strategically winning position.

12...♜b4 13.♚b3 a5 14.♙d2 ♜fd5 15.♚fd1 b6 16.e4 ♜c7 (16...♜f6N is a better try, although 17.♚ac1 ♙a6 18.♙e3 still gives White a clear plus) 17.♙xb4! axb4 18.♜d3± White was much better in Franco Alonso – Barez Menendez, Madrid 2005.

13.♜xe5

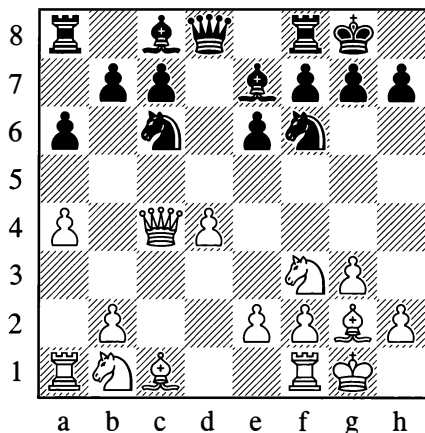
Many games have been played from this position, but the general assessment is obvious, as White keeps a pleasant advantage thanks to his powerful Catalan bishop. The following game remains as good an example as any:



13...♜d5 14.♜d3 ♙d6 15.♙d2 ♙d7 16.♚b3 a5 17.♚fd1±

Black was under annoying pressure in Tukmakov – Petursson, Bern 1991.

D3) 8...♖c6 9.♔xc4



Black has tried many different moves from here, but in most cases White will get an easy advantage with natural play. Rather than wasting space discussing a lot of inferior options in what is already a sideline, I will focus on a few of the more forcing options.

9...♔d5

This natural move has been the most popular choice by far. It is also worth briefly mentioning:

9...♖b4 10.♙d2 a5

10...b5?N fails to 11.♔b3 bxa4 12.♙xa4 a5 13.♖e5 and Black is in trouble.

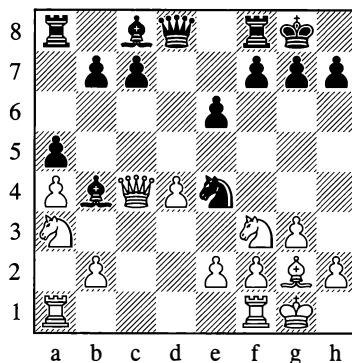
11.♖a3

11...♙d1!N is also worth considering.

11...♖e4 12.♙xb4 ♙xb4

12...axb4N 13.♖c2 ♙d7 14.a5 c6 15.a6 ♙xa6 16.♙xa6 bxa6 17.♔xa6 c5 18.♖e5 ♖f6 19.dxc5 ♙xc5 20.♖d3 leaves White with thematic Catalan pressure.

Now in Sturm – Raedeker, Wuerttemberg 1998, a logical continuation would have been:



13.♔c2N ♖f6 14.♖c4±

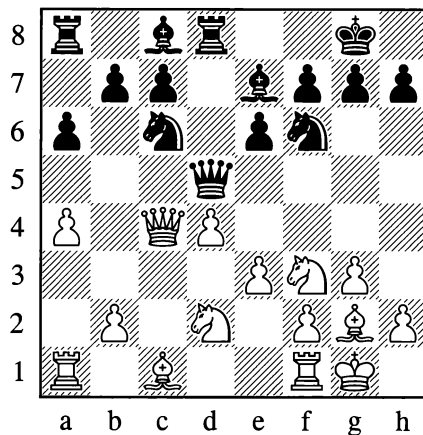
White enjoys a pleasant edge.

10.♖bd2 ♙d8

It is important to understand that the queenless position after 10...♔xc4 11.♖xc4 a5, as occurred in Quinteros – Sharif, Jakarta 1978, is quite pleasant for White. I suggest 12.♙d2N ♙d8 13.♙fc1 ♙d7 14.e3 ♖d5 15.♖e1 ♙e8 16.♖d3 when White maintains a small but stable edge.

11.e3

I was surprised to find well over a hundred games from this position. Once again, I will just focus on the few continuations that I consider most logical for Black.



11...♔h5

11...a5 was played in a recent game, which continued: 12.b3 (12.♖e2!?N also comes into consideration) 12...♗h5 13.♙b2 ♙d7 Zhou Weiqi – Wei Yi, China 2013. Now 14.♗ac1N looks natural, and if 14...♗ac8 15.e4!? ♖b4 16.♗e5 c5 17.♙f3 ♗h6 18.♖e2 White has a clear advantage.

11...♗xc4 12.♗xc4 ♗b8

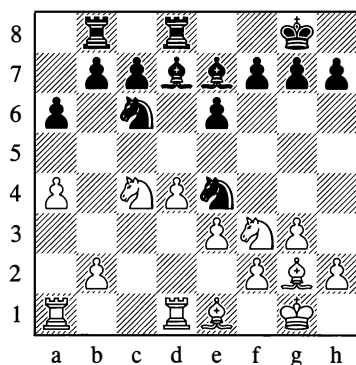
12...♙d7 13.♙d2 a5 14.♗fc1 ♗d5 transposes to 10...♗xc4 11.♗xc4 a5 12.♙d2N, as covered in the note to Black's 10th move above.

13.♙d1!

This is more accurate than 13.♙d2 ♗e4 14.♗fc1 ♗xd2 15.♗fxd2 ♗b4 16.♗b3 f6 when Black had an adequate game in Ftacnik – Beliavsky, Yerevan (ol) 1996.

13...♙d7 14.♙d2 ♗e4 15.♙e1

By keeping the dark-squared bishop alive, White maintains some pressure.



15...♙e8 16.♗dc1 ♗dc8

16...f6N 17.♗fd2 ♗xd2 18.♗xd2 ♙b4 19.♗c4 ♙xe1 20.♗xe1± also gives White the better game.

17.♗fe5 ♗xe5 18.♗xe5 ♗f6

Now in Wen Yang – Wei Yi, Danzhou 2013, White should have played:

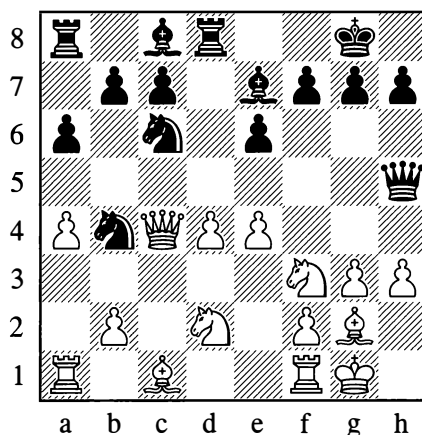
19.♗d3N

With a typical Catalan edge.

12.h3

I like to secure the kingside, while preparing a possible g3-g4 at a suitable moment. I will just mention one example from this position.

12...♗d5!? 13.e4 ♗db4



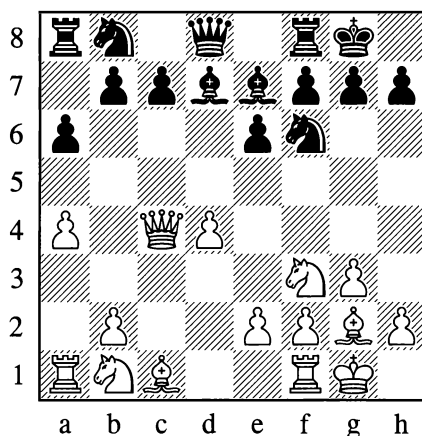
14.♗b3!?N

14.♗c3 brought White a convincing victory after 14...a5?! 15.♗c4 ♙f6 16.♙e3 h6 17.♗fd1 b6 18.♙f4 ♗d7 19.♗e3± when he was clearly better in Banusz – Sebenik, Sarajevo 2013. However, Black can improve with 14...f6!N 15.♗c4 b6, with an adequate position.

14...b6 15.♙d2 ♙b7 16.♗fc1 ♗ac8 17.a5!±

White has a pleasant game, with more space in the centre and some pressure on the queenside.

D4) 8...♙d7 9.♗xc4



9...♔c6

This is the obvious follow-up to Black's last move.

9...b5 is a risky move which weakens the queenside unnecessarily. 10.♖c2 ♘c6 11.♙e5! ♘b4 occurred in Hoffman – Franco, Sao Paulo 2001, and now White should have played 12.♗d2!N ♖b8 13.♙c3 bxa4 14.♙xa4 ♙b5 15.♞d1± with a pleasant edge.

10.♙f4

10.♙c3 b5! is fine for Black with the knight on c3 as a target. I also failed to find anything interesting after the most popular 10.♙g5, but fortunately the text move is more promising.

Black now has several options: **D41) 10...♙d5**, **D42) 10...♙d6**, **D43) 10...♙bd7**, and the most popular **D44) 10...a5**.

D41) 10...♙d5 11.♙d2!**11.♙c3**

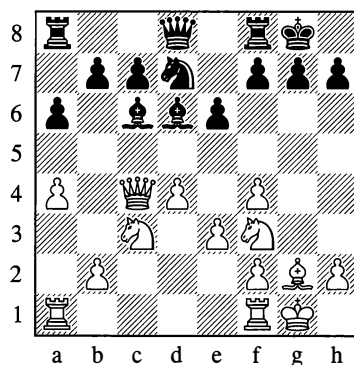
Despite having achieved a most memorable victory with this move, I must confess that it is not the best.

11...♙xf4 12.gxf4 ♙d6!

This seems most accurate. My game continued: 12...a5 13.♙e5 ♙xg2 14.♙xg2 c6 15.♞ad1 ♙a6 16.e3 ♙b4 17.♞g1 ♙d5 18.♙h1 f6?! This weakens the light squares and the kingside, and I was able to take full advantage. 19.♙f3 ♗b6 20.♗f1 ♗xb2 21.♙xd5 cxd5 22.f5! ♗b6 23.♗h3 ♞fe8 24.♞xg7+! ♙xg7 25.♞g1+ ♙h8 26.♙h4 h6 27.♙g6+ ♙h7 28.fxe6 ♖a6 29.♗f5 ♗xe6 30.♙f8+ 1–0 Avrukh – Sanikidze, Novi Sad 2009.

13.e3 ♙d7

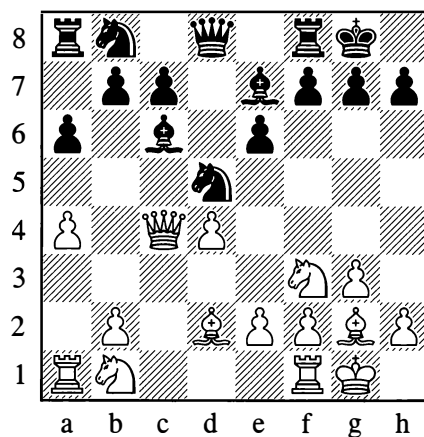
There was a time when I felt inspired by this type of structure with a half-open g-file, but objectively speaking the position is just unclear and double-edged. A good illustrative line is:

**14.♙h1 ♙f6 15.♞g1 ♙xf3!N**

15...♙e4?! 16.♙xe4 ♙xe4 17.♙g5! ♙xg2+ 18.♞xg2± was good for White in Kraai – Rosen, Indianapolis 2009, as his remaining knight was stronger than Black's bishop.

16.♙xf3 c6

Black has a solid position with balanced chances.

**11...♙d7**

It is important to mention that 11...♙b5?? does not work in view of 12.axb5 axb5 13.♗xd5! ♗xd5 14.♞xa8+– as first occurred in Kozul – Lekic, Neum 2004.

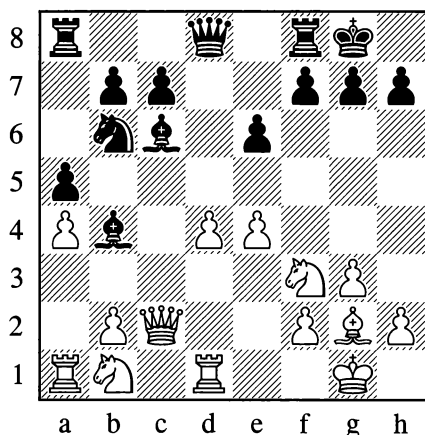
12.♞d1 a5 13.♗c2

I prefer this to 13.♗b3, which encourages 13...♞a6 followed by ...♞b6.

13...♙b4 14.♙xb4 ♙xb4 15.e4

White has gained space in the centre and enjoys a pleasant edge.

15...♖b6

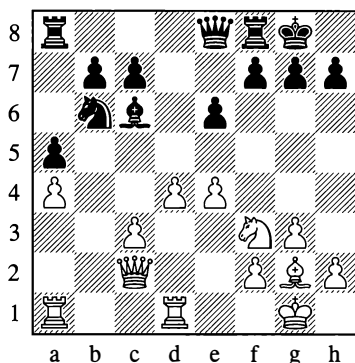


16.♗c3N

There is no point in leaping forward with 16.♗e5 ♙e8 17.♗c3 as in Buhmann – Poetsch, Schwaebisch Gmuend 2012, as Black could have played 17...f6N 18.♗f3 ♙h5, activating his light-squared bishop.

16...♙e8

Obviously White should take the possibility of 16...♙xc3 17.bxc3 ♖e8 into consideration. Black indeed grabs a pawn, but White gets fantastic compensation after:

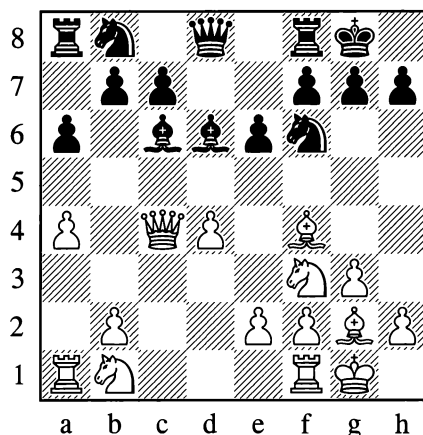


18.♞db1 ♙xa4 19.♞d3! followed by c4-c5.

17.♗a2 ♙e7 18.♗c1±

White retains a pleasant advantage.

D42) 10...♙d6



This recently came into fashion and has been played several times at the highest level.

11.♞c1!

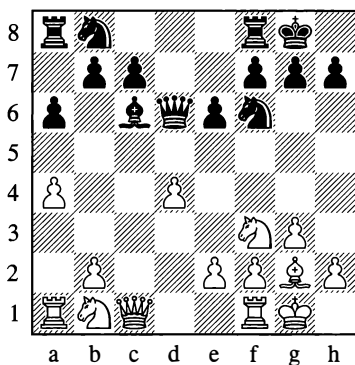
This rare move is White's most promising option. He fails to achieve any advantage after 11.♗c3 ♙xf4 12.gxf4 a5, or 11.♙g5 ♗bd7 12.♗c3 h6 13.♙xf6 ♗xf6. The latter line has been tested extensively at grandmaster level, but Black generally holds the position without much effort.

11...a5

I will take this as the main line, as it seems like the most logical move and was used successfully by Kramnik last year. Here are a few other possibilities:

11...♙xf4 12.♞xf4 ♞d6 13.♞c1!N

This is a pretty obvious improvement over 13.♞xd6 cxd6 14.♗bd2, when the arising endgame is harmless for Black, who can even simplify with 14...♙xf3!? 15.♙xf3 d5 16.♞fc1 ♗c6= as in Nowak – Bielavsky, Warsaw 1979.



13...♙d5

13...♙bd7 14.♙bd2 White intends ♗c2 followed by e2-e4, and if 14...♙e4 15.♙c4 ♗b4 16.♙fe5 ♙xe5 17.♙xe5 ♙d5 18.e3± he maintains the better game.

14.♙c3

14.♙bd2?! ♙c6 15.e3 ♙b4 looks solid enough for Black.

14...♙c6 15.e3 ♗ad8 16.a5±

11...♙bd7 12.♙c3 ♙e4 13.♗d1!

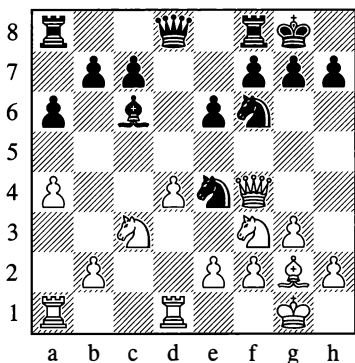
After this useful move, it transpires that all the central tension is favourable for White.

13...♙xf4

I also considered the ambitious 13...♙xc3!?N 14.bxc3 ♙b6, but after 15.a5 ♙c4 16.♗c2 ♙xf4 17.gxf4 ♗d5 18.♗a2! ♙d6 19.♗xd5 ♙xd5 (or 19...exd5 20.♙e5) 20.♙e5 White has the better endgame.

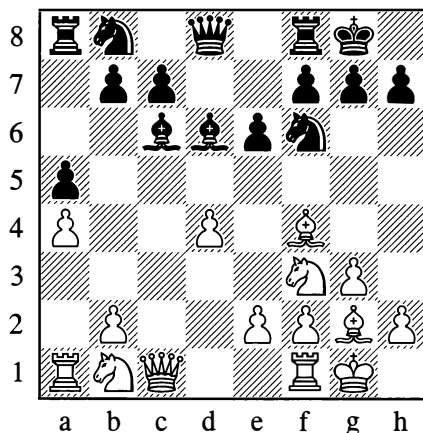
14.♗xf4 ♙df6

All this happened in P.H. Nielsen – Antonsen, Koge 2013. Here White could have increased his pressure by means of:



15.♙e5! ♙xc3 16.bxc3 ♙xg2 17.♙xg2 ♙d5 18.♗f3

White has a pleasant edge, with a central pawn majority, more active pieces and pressure on the queenside.



12.♙c3

12.♙d2?! is too passive, and after 12...♙bd7 13.♗d1 ♗e8 14.♙c3 ♙e4 15.♙fd2 f5 16.♙xe4 fxe4 17.♙e1 ♗h5 18.♙c3 ♙f6 Black easily obtained a comfortable position in Giri – Kramnik, Stavanger 2014.

12...♙a6 13.♗d1N

The only game from this position continued 13.♙g5 h6 14.♙h4 ♙xf3 15.♙xf6 (15.♙xf3 c6 does not change much) 15...♗xf6 16.♙xf3 c6 17.♗d1 ♗ad8 and Black had easily solved his problems in Fridman – Boruchovsky, Warsaw 2013.

The text move seems like an obvious attempt to improve. I will offer some illustrative lines showing logical play on both sides.

13...♙b4 14.♙g5

This seems like the most ambitious try.

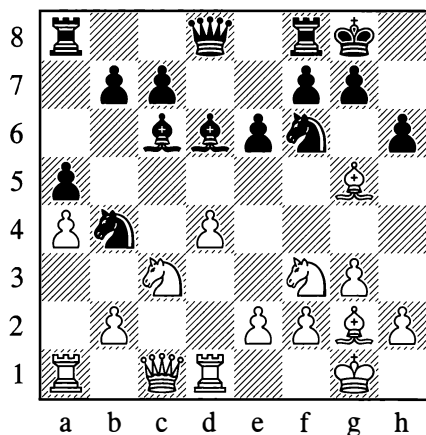
14.♙b5!? also deserves some attention. It is not clear if White will want to exchange on d6 with either the knight or the bishop, but

it certainly gives Black something to think about. You may wish to explore this in more detail by yourself, but I will just mention that 14...♗xf4 15.♖xf4 seems to favour White, for instance: 15...♘fd5 (or 15...♗xb5 16.axb5 ♖d7 17.♖g5! ♘bd5 18.♗f1!±) 16.♖c1 ♘b6 (16...♘f6 17.♘e5 ♗xg2 18.♔xg2±) 17.b3 ♗d5 18.♖b2 White keeps a slight pull.

14...h6

We will take this as the main line, as Black reacted similarly in the aforementioned Fridman – Boruchovsky game.

14...♗e7 is a playable alternative. White does not have anything serious, but he has the freedom to choose between two decent types of positions of differing characteristics. 15.♘e5 ♗xg2 16.♔xg2 ♘d7 17.♗xe7 ♖xe7 18.♘c4 reaches a solid position with a slight space advantage, while 15.♗xf6!? ♗xf6 16.e4 is a more ambitious idea, relinquishing the bishop pair in order to establish a strong pawn centre and stifle the c6-bishop.



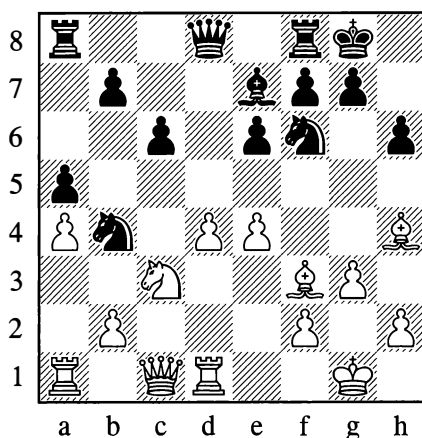
15.♗h4 ♗xf3

15...♗e7 16.♗xf6 ♗xf6 17.e4 can be compared with 14...♗e7 15.♗xf6!? above. The extra ...h6 move slightly favours White, as the typical plan of ...g6 followed by ...♗g7 will leave Black's kingside slightly less secure.

16.♗xf3 c6 17.e4

Compared to the Fridman – Boruchovsky game, the inclusion of the moves ♖d1 and ...♘b4 means that Black is unable to meet this move with ...e5.

17...♗e7



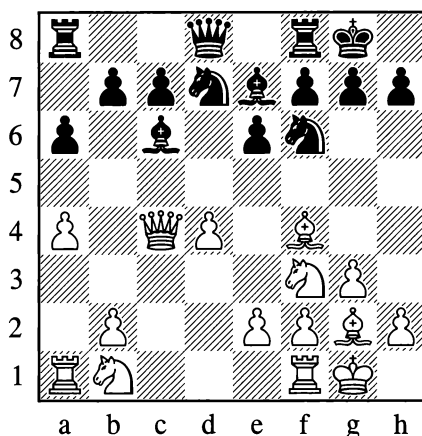
18.e5 ♘fd5

In the event of 18...♘d7 19.♗xe7 ♖xe7 20.♘e4 White keeps a slight pull.

19.♗xe7 ♖xe7 20.♘e4

We have reached a complex position where both sides have their trumps, but I slightly prefer White. One of the many possible ideas is to try and generate some kingside play with ♖a3, ♗h5, ♖f3 and so on.

D43) 10...♘bd7



This has been quite a popular choice. The drawback is that Black passes up the opportunity to make use of the weakened b4-square.

11. ♖c3

Now the three most important options are D431) 11...♙d6, D432) 11...♖c8 and D433) 11...♜b6.

It is worth briefly mentioning:

11...♜d5 12.♜xd5 exd5

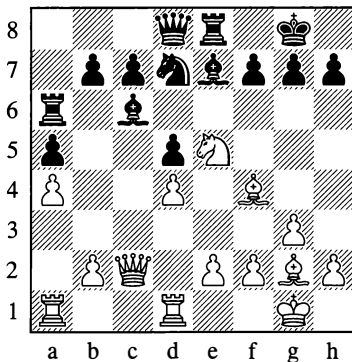
In the event of 12...♙d5N White should not rush to capture the c7-pawn, as 13.♞xc7 ♞xc7 14.♙xc7 ♖fc8 15.♞fc1 ♜c5! gives Black excellent chances to hold. 13.♞c2! is stronger, when Black must either allow e2-e4 with tempo or give up his light-squared bishop, both of which give White an obvious advantage.

13.♞c2

13.♞b3!?N could also be considered.

13...♞e8 14.♞fd1 a5 15.♜e5! ♞a6

Now in Parappalli – Ganesan, Calcutta 1992, White should have played:



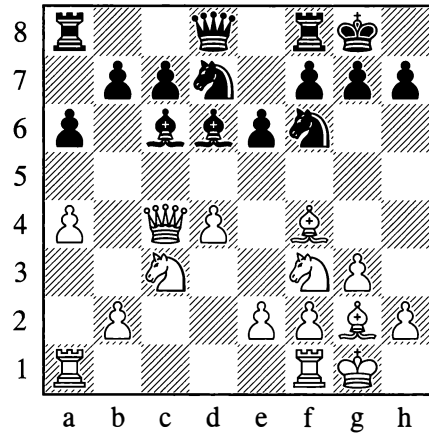
16.♜xc6!N bxc6

16...♞xc6 17.♞b3 ♜b6 18.♙d2! wins the a5-pawn, but the text move is not much fun for Black either.

17.e4

White has a serious advantage.

D431) 11...♙d6



This move has been tried by several strong players, but White's best reply is almost unknown.

12.♙d2!?

This is almost a novelty, having occurred in just a single email game.

12...♜e4

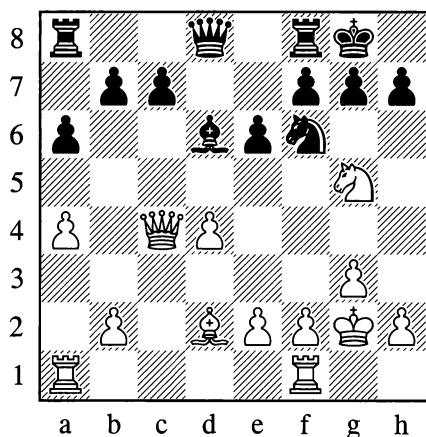
The quiet 12...♞e7N enables White to establish control over the e4-square: 13.♞fe1 ♙b4 14.♜e4 ♜d5 15.♙xb4 ♞xb4 16.♞c2±

I also considered 12...♜b6N 13.♞d3 ♜bd5 14.♜xd5 ♙xd5 (14...exd5 15.♜e5 looks promising for White) 15.♙g5 ♙e7 16.♙xf6 ♙xf6 17.e4 ♙c6 18.♞fd1 ♞d7 19.b3 ♞fd8 20.♞ac1 and White is slightly better.

13.♜xe4 ♙xe4 14.♜g5!

A well-timed operation. Once again, the main idea is to win control over the e4-square.

14...♙xg2 15.♙xg2 ♜f6

**16.♙a1!N**

There is no point in rushing with 16.e4 h6 17.e5 when a draw was agreed in Kipso – Dmitriev, email 2010. Indeed, after 17...♘d5 18.exd6 hxg5 Black is not worse.

The text move just leads to a calm position where White has a slight space advantage and better central control.

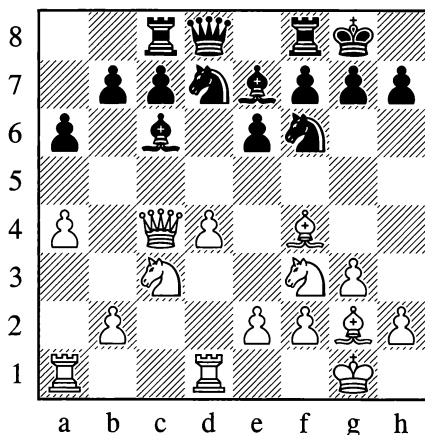
16...h6

16...♙c8 runs into the annoying 17.♙b3!.

17.♘f3 ♘e4 18.♙a5

White maintains some pressure.

D432) 11...♙c8 12.♙fd1



This seems like the most flexible choice. The next few moves are logical, and have occurred a few times in practice.

12...♘b6 13.♙b3 ♘bd5 14.♙g5!

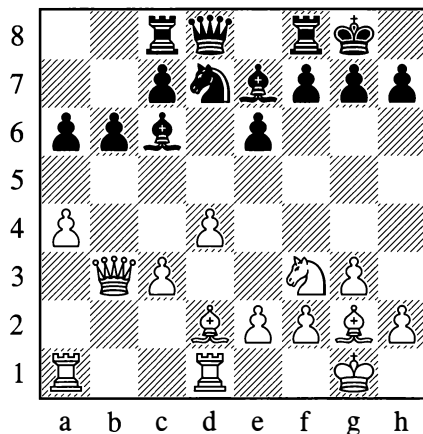
This strong move enables White to develop some pressure.

14...♘d7

14...h6 15.♙xf6 ♙xf6 16.♘e4! ♙e7 occurred in Buhmann – Oud, Bad Wiessee 2010. At this point the most convincing way to increase White's advantage would have been 17.♘e1!N, for instance: 17...♙fd8 18.♘xf6† ♙xf6 19.e4 ♘b6 20.a5 ♘d7 21.♘c2±

15.♙d2 ♘xc3 16.bxc3 b6

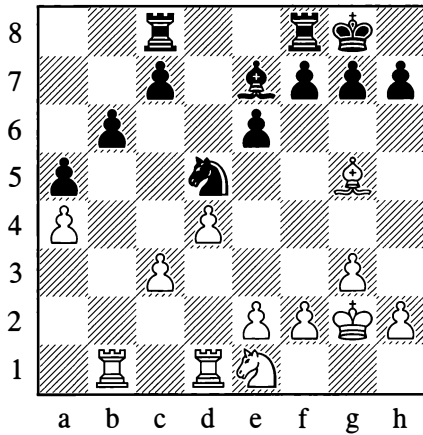
This position occurred in Miton – Bulski, Warsaw 2010, and now I like the following idea.

**17.♙c4!N ♙b7 18.♘e1 ♙xg2 19.♘xg2 a5**

From now on, the thematic ...c5 will leave Black with a permanent weakness on b6.

20.♙ab1 ♘f6 21.♙g5 ♙d5† 22.♙xd5 ♘xd5

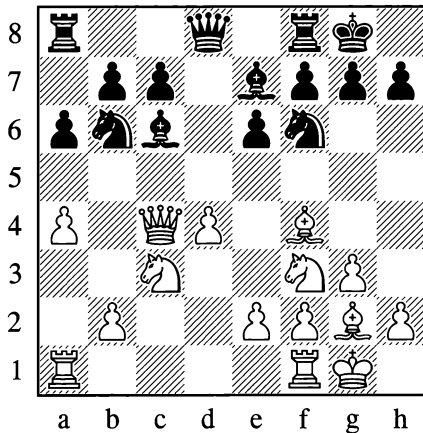
22...exd5 23.e3 leaves White with the straightforward plan of ♙dc1, ♘d3, ♙xf6 and c3-c4, with a lot of pressure.



23. Qxe7 Qxe7 24. e4

Despite the simplifications, White can continue pressing for a long time.

D433) 11... Qb6



This has been the most popular choice by far.

12. Wd3!

12. Wb3 has scored slightly higher, but I failed to discover any advantage for White after 12... Qfd5!.

12... Qbd5

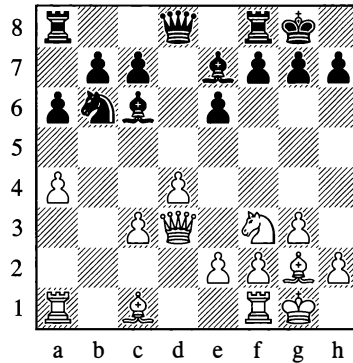
An important alternative is:
12... Qfd5 13. Qc1!N

This is my new idea, offering a pawn sacrifice. Most games have continued 13. Qxd5 Qxd5 14. Qd2 Qf6 when Black is perfectly okay.

13... Qxc3

13... Qb4 should be met by 14. Wd1, which explains why the bishop went to c1 rather than d2 on the previous move. Now White is nicely coordinated and ready for e2-e4.

14. bxc3

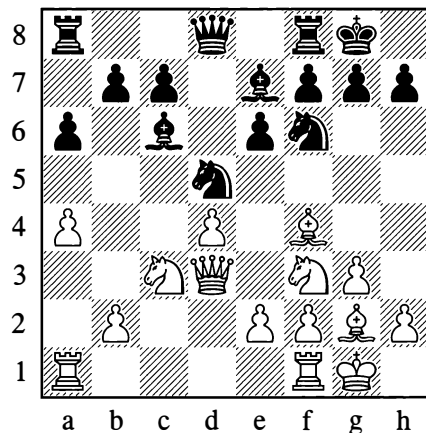


14... Qxa4

14... Qxa4 15. c4 gives White excellent compensation while also setting a nice trap: the logical 15... c5 runs into 16. Qd2! when it is hard for Black to deal with the Qa5 threat.

15. c4

White's powerful centre gives him plenty of compensation for the pawn.



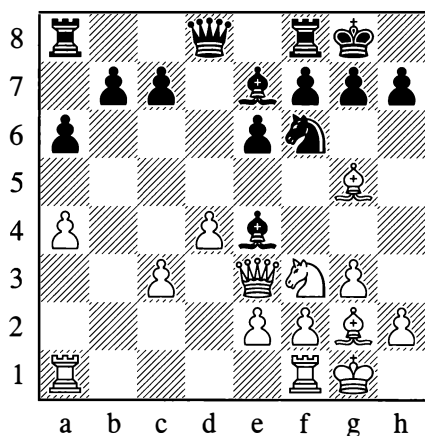
13. Qg5

Several players have exchanged knights on d5, but I see absolutely no point in doing so.

13...♘xc3

13...♘b4 has been played twice, but for some reason neither White player chose 14.♙b1N, fighting for control over e4. A logical continuation is: 14...h6 15.♙xf6 ♙xf6 16.e4 ♙d7 (16...♙xd4? 17.♙d1 e5 18.♘xe5! is clearly better for White) 17.♙d1 We have reached a typical double-edged middlegame, where I would favour White's strong centre over Black's bishop pair.

14.bxc3 ♙e4 15.♙e3



15...♙d5

15...♙c6 16.a5 h6 17.♙xf6 ♙xf6 has been played a few times. A good example for White is: 18.♙d3! ♙d6 (18...♙b8 19.e4±) 19.♙fb1 ♙b5 20.c4 ♙c6 21.e3 White maintained a favourable position in Djoudi – Migliorini, email 2005.

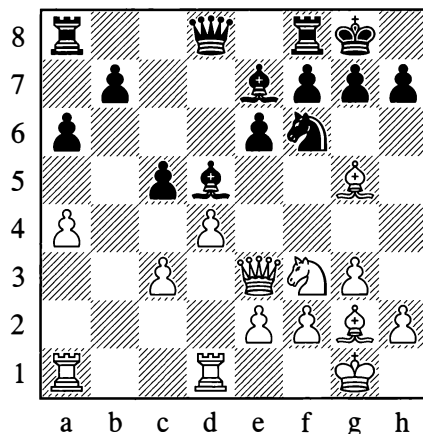
16.♙fd1

White should not force the issue with 16.♙xf6 ♙xf6 17.♙d3, as 17...c5 18.e4 ♙c6∞ led to double-edged play in Cummings – Upton, Pula 1997.

16...c5

In the event of 16...♙c8 White is better placed to take action in the centre: 17.♙xf6! ♙xf6 18.♙d3 c5 19.e4 ♙c6 20.d5! exd5 21.exd5 ♙d7 22.♘d2±

This position occurred in Luppi – Lotti, corr. 1998. Here I found a remarkable idea:



17.c4!N ♙xc4 18.dxc5 ♙c7

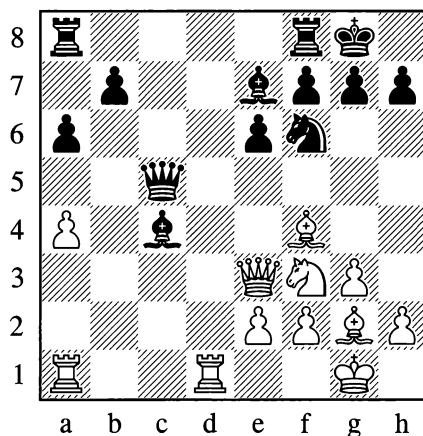
18...♙d5 19.♘e5 retains some pressure for White.

19.♙f4!

An important follow-up.

19...♙xc5

If the queen moves somewhere else then White's bishop comes to d6 with a lot of power.

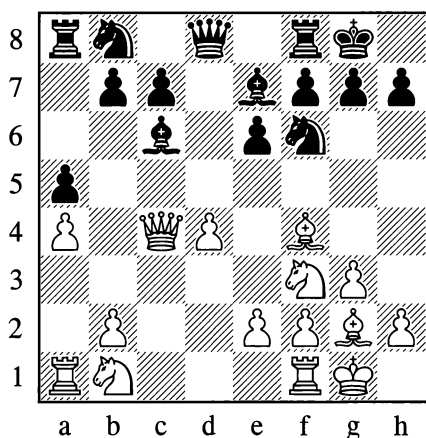


20. ♖xc5 ♙xc5 21. ♖dc1 ♖ac8

21...b5 is hardly a good idea in view of 22. ♖e5! ♖ad8 23. ♖xc4 bxc4 24. ♖xc4 with a clear advantage for White.

22. ♖xc4 ♙xf2† 23. ♖xf2 ♖xc4 24. ♖d2

Materially Black is okay for the moment, but White is still the clear favourite, with two strong bishops against a rook.

D44) 10...a5

This is Black's most popular choice by some margin. By fixing the b4-square as an outpost, Black highlights one of the main drawbacks of the 8.a4 variation.

11. ♖c3 ♖a6

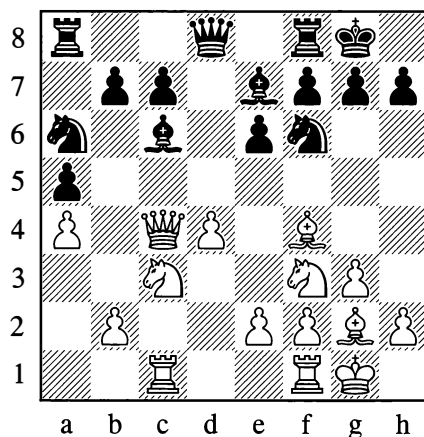
This logical follow-up has been almost universally played.

I found one example where Black placed his bishop on b4 instead of the knight: 11...♙b4 12. ♖e5 (I also like 12. ♖fd1N ♖bd7 13. ♖e5 ♙xg2 14. ♖xg2 ♖b6 15. ♖d3 ♖e7 16. e4 ♖fd8 17. ♖f3 with a pleasant edge.) 12...♙xg2 13. ♖xg2 ♖d5 14. ♖d3! (This is stronger than 14. ♙d2, when 14...♖b6 15. ♖d3 ♖d8 16. ♖f3 ♖e7 17. e4 e5 leads to balanced play.) 14...♖c6 This was Diermair – Boensch, Austria 2013, and now the simple 15. ♖fd1N would have maintained a nice edge for White.

12. ♖ac1!

All of White's sensible-looking rook moves have been tested numerous times, but a deep investigation convinced me that the text move is the best way to fight for an advantage.

12. ♖e5 ♙xg2 13. ♖xg2 is the main alternative, which has been tested extensively at a high level. Black's most reliable reply seems to be 13...♖d5 14. ♖ad1 ♖xf4† 15. gxf4 ♙d6!. Sergei Karjakin has demonstrated the viability of Black's position, having scored two wins and three draws with no defeats, against world-class opposition.

**12...♖b4**

Many other moves have been tried, but the text is the most logical and popular.

I will not discuss every Black option in detail, as the general plans will tend to remain pretty similar. Here is one alternative which slightly alters the character of the game:

12...♙d6

This has been tested by such strong players as Bacrot and Beliavsky.

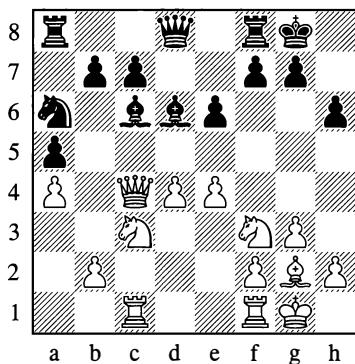
13. ♙g5!

13. ♖e5 can be met by 13...♙d5!N 14. ♖xd5 exd5 when Black is perfectly okay.

13...h6 14. ♙xf6 ♖xf6 15. e4 ♖d8

15...e5 is a playable alternative, although in

Pawlus – Zawadka, corr. 1992, the accurate 16.♘d5!N ♚e6 17.♚c2! ♜ad8 18.♞fd1 would have retained better chances for White.



16.♞fd1 ♖b4

In Harika – Melia, Plovdiv 2010, White definitely had the better game, the only real question being how to improve his position.

I would recommend the knight manoeuvre:

17.♘d2!N ♙e7 18.♘f1

Followed by ♘e3 and, at a suitable moment, advancing the f-pawn.

12...h6

This move has brought Black a good score, but I am not a big fan of it. True, Black prevents a future ♙g5, but the weakening of the g6-square may make it harder for Black to chase the white knight from e5 later.

13.♞fd1!

13.♞fe1 ♙b4 makes it hard for White to carry out e2-e4, so it is better to put the rook on the d-file.

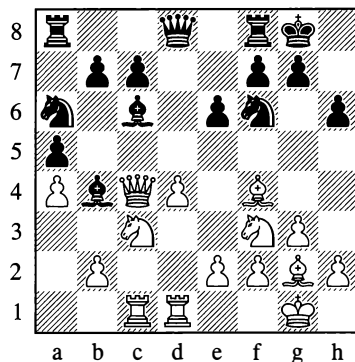
13...♙b4

This is a typical idea to establish control over the e4-square, but it leaves the knight misplaced on a6.

13...♖b4N immediately transposes to another game, and after 14.♘e5 ♙xg2 15.♙xg2 White had a pleasant edge in Mastrovasilis – Forsaa, Gibraltar 2013. The position is the same as the main line, except

for the insertion of the moves ♞fd1 and ...h6, which undoubtedly favours White.

13...♙d6 was played in Stoll – Gerigk, Germany 1997, and now I don't see any reason to refrain from the standard plan: 14.♘e5N ♙xg2 15.♙xg2 ♖b4 (15...♖h5 16.♙d2 does not help Black) 16.e4± White achieves his optimal set-up.



14.♘e5 ♙xg2 15.♙xg2 ♖b4

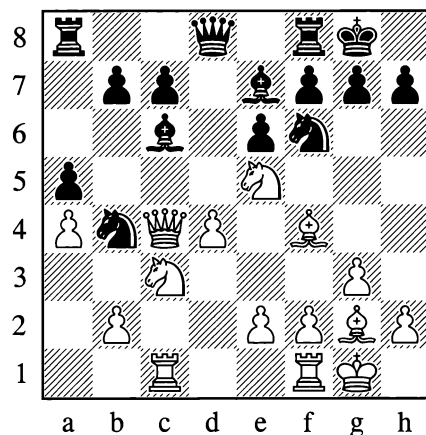
15...c6 16.♚b3 ♘d5 17.♙d2± did not change much in Morrow – Wilhelmi, corr. 2014.

16.♙d2 c6 17.e4 ♘f6 18.f3 ♘d7 19.♘d3±

White had a nice edge in Johnston – Reis, corr. 2013.

13.♘e5

13.♞fe1 has been tried by several strong players, including Kasparov, but it seems to me that 13...♙d6 should be fine for Black.



13...♙xg2

This is the only move to have been played, with good reason.

13...♙d5?! is a thematic idea in similar positions, but after 14.♘xd5 exd5? 15.♖xc7 White wins a pawn while highlighting the importance of placing the rook on c1, rather than some other square, on move 12. Black would therefore have to resign himself to 14...♘fxd5, and after 15.♙d2 c6 16.♗fd1 White's bishop pair gives him a pleasant edge.

14.♙xg2 ♘fd5

This is Black's first choice by far. Without it, he risks falling into a passive situation.

14...c6 allows White to seize space in the centre, although Black remains pretty solid. A good example continued: 15.e4 ♘d7 16.♘f3! Avoiding unnecessary exchanges. 16...♖b6 (16...♖c8 17.♖e2± brought me a recent victory in Avrukh – Fedorovsky, Germany 2014.) 17.♗fd1 ♘f6 18.♘e5 ♗fd8 19.♙e3 ♖a6 20.f3 ♘d7 21.♖xa6 ♗xa6 22.♘c4!± White maintained an edge in Sasikiran – Talla, Czech Republic 2012, and went on to win a nice game.

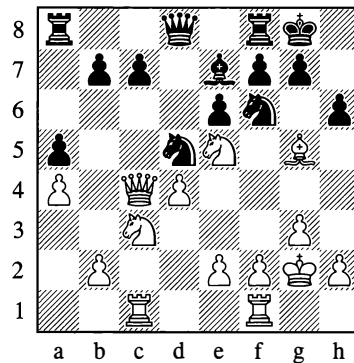
14...♘bd5 15.♙g5!?N

White can of course play 15.♘xd5 and transpose to one of the two main lines given below. The text move could also be considered as an attempt to punish Black's last move.

15...h6

15...♘b6 16.♖d3 h6 (16...c6 17.e4 ♘fd7 18.♙xe7 ♖xe7 19.♘f3 Having a stable space advantage, White is not interested in trading a pair of knights. 19...♗ad8 20.b3±) 17.♙f4 (I generally prefer to keep my bishop, although 17.♙xf6 ♙xf6 18.♘f3 is another route to a slight edge.) 17...♘fd5 18.♘xd5 ♘xd5 19.♙d2 The position is similar to

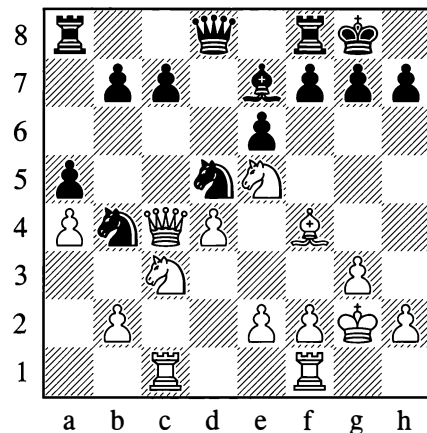
variation D4422 below. The position of the white queen on d3 instead of c4 is pretty inconsequential, but the inclusion of ...h6 is slightly unfavourable for Black, as he may find it harder to chase the knight away with ...f6 due to the weakening of the g6-square.

**16.♙xf6**

This time I think White should exchange, as 16.♙d2 ♘b6 17.♖d3 ♘fd5 is not so clear.

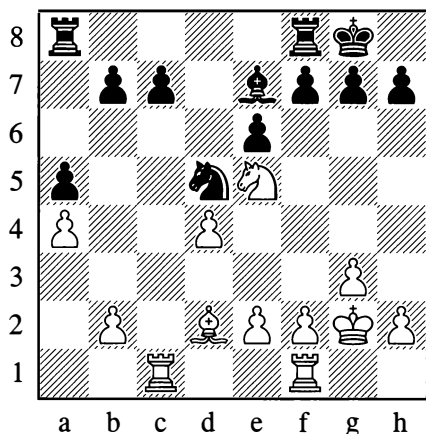
16...♘xf6 17.e4

White keeps a typical slight pull. Even the more restrained 17.♗fd1!? c6 18.♖b3 ♖b8 19.♘c4 ♙b4 20.e3 looks sufficient for a tiny edge. I am not sure if this line is really any better than transposing to the lines below with 15.♘xd5, but it is always useful to have more than one decent option.

**15.♘xd5**

Now Black must decide whether or not to exchange queens. We will analyse **D441) 15...♖xd5†** and **D442) 15...♜xd5** in turn.

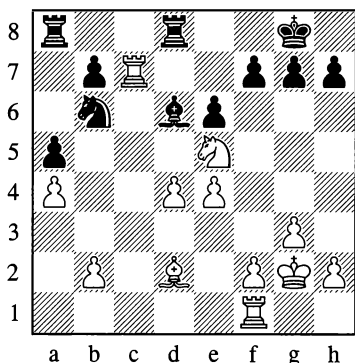
D441) 15...♖xd5† 16.♖xd5 ♜xd5 17.♙d2



This endgame is deceptively tricky for Black to handle, and he will have to work hard to equalize. According to the database, White has won more games than he has drawn from this position, and has yet to suffer a single defeat.

17...c6

Worse is: 17...♜fd8?! 18.e4 ♜b6? (18...♜f6N is a better try, but after 19.♜xc7 ♜xd4 20.♜f3 ♜d7 21.♜c4± Black's position is quite unpleasant.) 19.♜xc7 ♙d6 Now the strongest continuation would have been:



20.♜c2!N (20.♜xb7 gave White an advantage

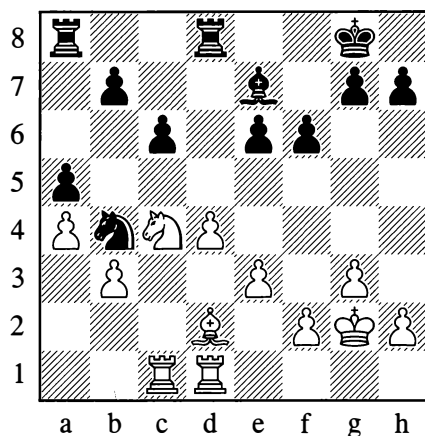
and an eventual win in Wang Yue – Onischuk. Ningbo 2011, but the text move is even better.) 20...♙xe5 21.dxe5 ♜xa4 22.♜a1 ♜c5 23.♜xa5± White has a serious advantage.

18.♜fd1

I also like 18.♜d3!N, with the idea to jump to c5 at a suitable moment. A plausible continuation is 18...♜fd8 19.e3 f6 20.♜fd1 ♜f7 21.h4 and White retains some pressure.

18...♜fd8 19.♜c4 ♜b4 20.e3 f6 21.b3

Black remains pretty solid, but the position is much easier to handle for White, as evidenced by a practical score of 4/4 from here.



21...♜f7

Another instructive example continued 21...♜a6 22.♜f3 h5 23.♜e2 ♜d7 24.h3 ♜f~ 25.g4 hxg4 26.hxg4 ♜a2 27.♜a1 ♜b4 28.g5!± when White managed to seize the initiative on the kingside in Stefanova – Xu Yuhua. Ulaanbaatar 2010.

22.f4 b5?!

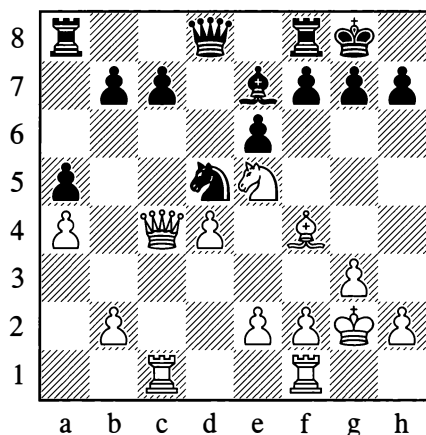
This is not a good idea, as Black will be left with a permanent weakness on c6. Objectively he should have defended passively, even though it would not have been much fun.

23.♜b2 bxa4 24.♙xb4! axb4 25.♜xa4 ♜a6

26.♙f3 h6 27.h4 h5 28.♙e4 g6 29.♞c4

Black was doomed to suffer for a long time in Meyner – Wosch, email 2013.

D442) 15...♜xd5

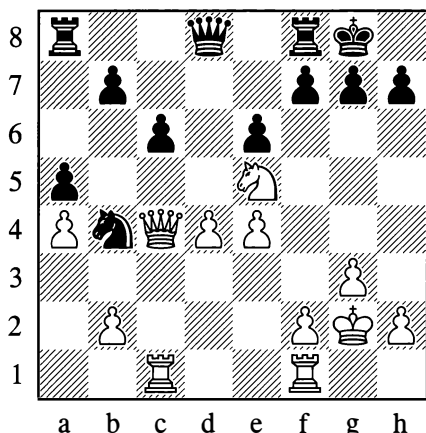


This seems like a better choice for Black, avoiding the passivity of the previous line.

16.♙d2

Now we have a final split. D4421) 16...♙b4 has been played by a few strong GMs, but the most popular choice has been D4422) 16...c6.

D4421) 16...♙b4 17.♙xb4 ♜xb4 18.e4 c6



19.♞fd1

19.f4 is a bit too aggressive, and after 19...♙h8 20.♞fd1 f6 21.♜f3 ♞d7 22.b3 ♞ad8 23.♞d2 ♞fe8 24.h4 ♞f7 25.♞e1 ♞h5 White was left without many constructive ideas in Topalov – Jakovenko, Nanjing 2009.

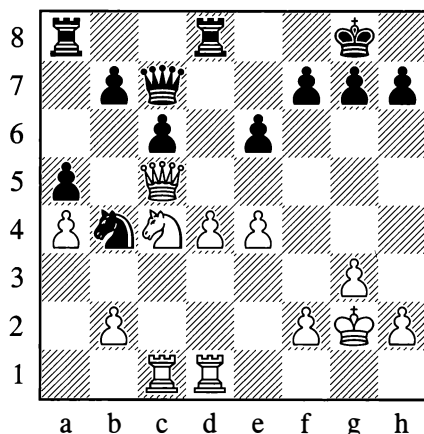
19...♞e7 20.♞c5!

20.♞e2N ♞ad8 21.♜c4 ♞c7 22.e5 is another possible plan, but White must take into account the possible exchange sacrifice 22...♞d5 23.♜d6 ♞xd6! 24.exd6 ♞xd6, when it will be hard to break Black's defence.

20...♞c7 21.♜c4 ♞fd8

I also considered 21...f5!N 22.♞d6! (but not 22.f3 fxe4 23.fxe4 ♞f7 24.♞f1? ♞g6 when suddenly White is in trouble) 22...♞xd6 23.♜xd6 ♞ab8 24.f3 ♞fd8 25.♜c4 b6 26.♞d2 and White retains a slight advantage.

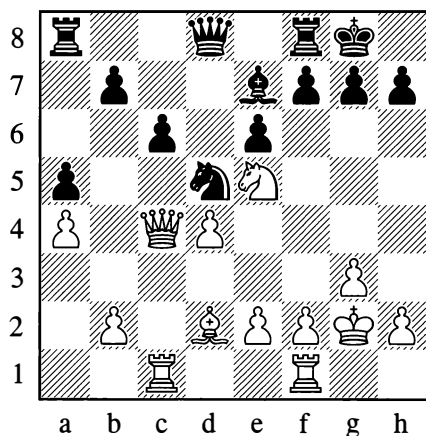
White had a small but stable advantage in Ni Hua – Kravtsov, Dubai 2012. At this point the best way to increase the pressure would have been:



22.♞c3!N

The rook may go to b3, creating the tactical threat of ♜xa5, or it may go to the kingside via f3 and f4 to create threats there. White definitely keeps the better prospects, and can continue probing without taking any risks.

D4422) 16...c6



17.♙fd1!

White had better include this useful supporting move before he advances the e-pawn, as demonstrated by the following game:

17.e4 ♘b6!

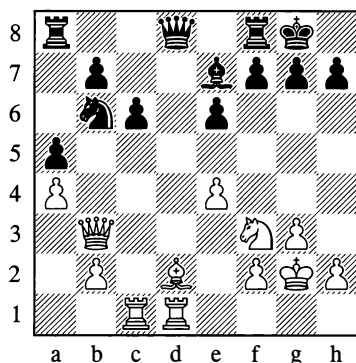
17...♘b4 was Anand's choice in a rapid game, but the text move gives White some problems with the defence of his pawns.

18.♙b3

18.♙d3 ♙f6! (Black should not rush with 18...♘xa4?! 19.♙a1!) 19.♘f3 ♘xa4 20.♙a3 ♘b6 21.♙xa5 ♙a6! 22.♙c3 was played in Ashwin – A. Rychagov, Paleochora 2011, and now the simple 22...♙d7N 23.♙b4 ♙fa8 leaves Black with nothing to worry about.

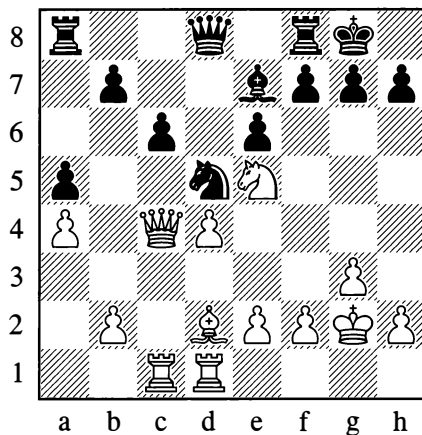
18...♙xd4 19.♘f3 ♙d8 20.♙fd1

Black only has one move, but it is good enough.



20...♙a6! 21.♙xa5 ♙c7 22.♙c3 ♙fa8 23.♙xb6 ♙xb6

Black held relatively easily in Wang Yue – Wang Hao, Shenzhen 2011.



17...♘b6

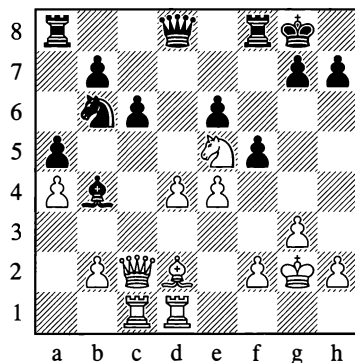
Black has also tried:

17...♙b4 18.e4!N

18.♙xb4 ♘xb4 19.e4 transposes to variation D4421 above, and was the actual move order of the Ni Hua – Kravtsov game. The text move is an independent alternative which also gives White some advantage.

18...♘b6 19.♙c2 f5!?

Obviously the d4-pawn is untouchable, as 19...♙xd4? 20.♙f4! wins material.



20.♙b3 ♙d6 21.f3 fxe4 22.fxe4 ♘d7
22...♙xd4? 23.♙xe4† ♘h8 24.♙xb4+

23.♙xb4 axb4 24.♘c4 ♖e7 25.e5±

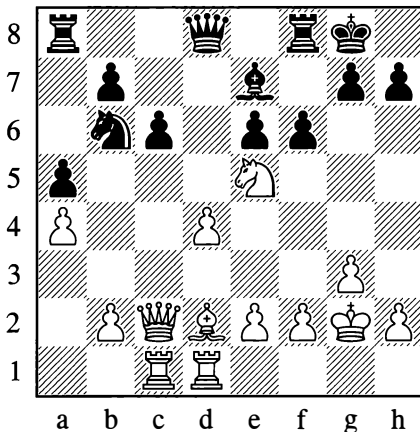
White clearly has the better game.

18.♖c2!

18.♖b3 enabled Black to equalize comfortably with 18...♖d5† 19.♖xd5 exd5= in Z. Tan – Melia, Mardin 2011.

18...f6

18...♖xd4? is a bad idea in view of 19.♙xa5! ♖xe5 20.♙xb6 when White is clearly better, thanks to his control over the d-file. The continuation might be: 20...♖a6 21.a5 ♙b4 22.♖d7 ♖aa8 (After 22...♙xa5 23.♙c5 ♖e8 24.♖xb7 Black is helpless against the simple plan of ♖d1-d7.) 23.♖xb7 ♙xa5 24.♙e3± White will soon be able to pick up the c-pawn.



19.♙f3 ♖d7 20.e4 ♘c8 21.♙e3±

We have been following the game Martinez Martin – Bieliauskas, corr. 2012. White maintains a typical slight edge for such positions. His centre is secure and he can continue making small improvements, while Black must constantly be on the lookout for ideas such as d4-d5.

Conclusion

The set-up with 4...♙e7, 5...0–0 and 6...dxc4 can perhaps be considered the absolute main line of the Catalan. After 7.♖c2 we started by checking the sidelines 7...c5 and 7...♙d7, both of which are pretty respectable, yet also have clear drawbacks that we can aim to exploit. On the other hand, 7...b5!? has proved to be something of a revelation since *GM 1*. I believe that the pawn sacrifice starting with 8.a4 b4 9.♘fd2! is promising for White, but careful study is needed.

The big main line is 7...a6, when 8.a4 is a major departure from *GM 1*. After the standard 8...♙d7 9.♖xc4 ♙c6 10.♙f4, it took me a lot of analytical effort, as well as my own practical testing, to identify the most promising paths. Perhaps the most important general rule is that White should almost always avoid having his bishop exchanged on f4 by an enemy knight. Many strong GMs (including myself) have allowed it, believing the open g-file and additional central control (after gxf4) to be beneficial. However, it has become clear to me that this structure ‘only’ leads to an interesting game, with no objective advantage if Black plays correctly.

Thus, whenever a black knight goes to d5, we should generally retreat the bishop to d2, or occasionally even c1. White’s general aim will be to take control over the e4-square and seize some space in the centre. This often leads to nagging pressure, even after further piece exchanges. Another important point in the most popular D44 variation is that the outpost on b4 does not seem to be of much use to Black. Although White’s advantage is often pretty small, it will often persist into the endgame, without involving much risk at all.